
Fewer rooms than mattresses: Student housing crisis spills beyond Satya Niketan

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Walk two kilometres from any Delhi University college gate, or step off a metro at Mukherjee Nagar's UPSC hub, and the geography repeats itself with grim consistency: narrow buildings stacked floor upon floor.

Bunk beds crammed into rooms with barely enough space to turn, and staircases never meant to carry this much daily traffic. The Satya Niketan collapse killed seven people on September 6. It also confirmed what students across the city had been saying for years: The building that fell could have been any of theirs.

In Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi's crowded coaching hub for UPSC and SSC aspirants, stu-

dents described the conditions they live in day to day.

"The rooms are pathetic and quite congested, with hardly space to breathe," one job aspirant said, describing kitchens that lack basic hygiene, forcing residents to depend on local dhabas for food.

PGs in the area charge ₹30,000 to ₹40,000 for a single room, and between ₹10,000 and ₹20,000 for shared accommodation, students said, with owners frequently demanding six months' rent upfront, amounting to ₹1 to 1.5 lakh in security deposits at the time of booking. "It's very hard to survive here in Mukherjee Nagar with sky-rocketing room rents sans basic facilities," one student said.

On safety, another lodger was blunter still, saying most



Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) officials inspect student paying guest (PG) accommodations in the Satya Niketan area following the collapse of a multi-storey building in New Delhi on Wednesday

hostels in the area do not even maintain a fire extinguisher. "I will request Government and administration to take stock of the situation and do the needful," he said. That request has been made before, and largely ignored.

The pattern extends across

the city's rental geography. Reporting by Urban Acres mapped the crisis across areas including Munirka, Satya Niketan, Kalu Sarai and Laxmi

Nagar, describing narrow multi-storey buildings converted into hostel-like arrangements, with bunk beds in small rooms and internet connections strung across different landings. Students in these areas reported paying between ₹8,000 and ₹20,000 a month for a shared bed, with the report citing an estimate from the National Trade Confederation that student rental accommodation across Delhi contributes roughly ₹45,000 crore to the local economy, a market built almost entirely on properties that were never zoned or approved for this scale of habitation.

The scale of demand explains why students keep choosing buildings they know are unsafe. Around 71,600 new undergraduate

students joined Delhi University in the current academic session, while the university has only around 7,000 hostel seats, and just 20 of its 91 colleges offer any hostel facility at all, according to figures cited by students speaking to The Federal. The rest are left to negotiate a private market where, as one protesting student put it at the Satya Niketan site, "Yeh haadsa nahi, hatya hai," this is not an accident, it is murder, a slogan aimed less at any single landlord than at a system that has let this gap widen for years.

Vikram, a student at Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma College, described how owners demand three months' rent in advance along with a deposit, offer food of "incredibly poor" quality, and divide rooms

using makeshift partitions, often without fire clearances and with only a single exit from buildings packed into narrow lanes. Simran, a former resident of Satya Niketan, told the same paper she recognised the collapsed building instantly on her phone screen because her own PG once stood two buildings away.

From Mukherjee Nagar's smouldering staircases to Satya Niketan's collapsed floors, the complaint from students is identical, repeated in city after city map, rupee after rupee of advance rent: there are simply more students in Delhi than there are safe rooms to hold them, and until that changes, they say, the next collapse is only a matter of which building's foundation gives way first.

PG safety crackdown after building collapse leaves students scrambling for shelter

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A city-wide safety survey of paying guest accommodations (PGs) following the Satya Niketan building collapse has left students in a lurch over their stay, as civic authorities seal and demolish unauthorised structures across the capital.

Aditya, a student at Delhi University's South Campus, is among those temporarily staying in classrooms after his PG in Chirag Delhi was sealed by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) amid the ongoing survey.



Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) personnel dismantle an unsafe adjacent structure following the multi-storey building collapse tragedy at Satya Niketan in New Delhi on Wednesday

immediate arrangements for their stay. At Laxmi Nagar's Shree Shyam PG, however, students said they have not faced any major problems with the accommodation so far, even as the ongoing inspections have made them think more closely about building safety and emergency arrangements.

Rahul, who has been staying at the PG for around two-and-a-half years, said he pays Rs 3,500 in monthly rent and has found the facilities satisfactory. However, the Satya Niketan building collapse has made him question whether the accommodation he lives in is safe.

"There is always a fear because we never know what

may go wrong. This safety audit should have happened earlier, before an accident," he said.

Another student said the inspections have raised concerns about what would happen if they were asked to vacate their PG. "If we are being asked to vacate now, where will we go? Finding another place at such short notice is not easy, and we also do not know whether the next building will be safe."

Laxmi Nagar resident Mohammad Salman Siddiqui, an interior designer, said his family has been very concerned since the Satya Niketan tragedy. "My family members keep asking whether my PG is safe, as they

have never visited the accommodation themselves."

The MCD, on the other hand, has initiated safety checks of buildings housing PGs across the city.

Arvind, a junior engineer in the Laxmi Nagar building department, said officials are surveying the accommodations to ascertain whether they are compliant with safety and other statutory requirements.

"We are checking whether the buildings have fire NOC (no-objection certificate), their age, number of entry and exit points, payment of conversion charges, and whether owners have the required licence to run PGs," he said.

Satya Niketan collapse: Wall removed for shop, basement filled with debris before crash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A ground-floor wall had been removed to make space for a shop on the day the five-storey PG building in Delhi's Satya Niketan crashed. Police investigation reveals that the basement had been undergoing repairs for eight to 10 days after waste and water accumulated there following several days of rain. Three truckloads of debris were filled into the basement to level it with the ground floor.



Debris litters the site during the ongoing demolition and clearing operations following a multi-storey building collapse tragedy at Satya Niketan in New Delhi on Wednesday

The labour contractor, Sanoj Kumar, carrying out the work told the police that he was hired by building owner Hariram Gupta's son Mahesh around 10 days before the incident and was paid ₹2,800 per day.

Kumar (35), a resident of JJ Camp Moti Bagh and a permanent resident of Manikpur village in Bihar's Banka, was apprehended in Uttar Pradesh's Kasganj and brought to Delhi, where he was arrested and questioned, a senior police officer said.

"On the day of the incident, a wall on the ground floor that was obstructing space meant for a shop was removed. The building could not withstand the load after the wall was removed and ultimately collapsed," the officer said, even as fresh

details emerge as police examine the construction, renovation and maintenance work carried out at the building. Repair work was also underway on the ground floor for an extension, allegedly for commercial purposes, when the structure collapsed.

Police said the other accused arrested in the case, Sudhanshu Lovneesh (31), a resident of Bhajanpura, was operating the PG in Satya Niketan with his friend Shubham Tyagi on a lease under the name 'Hostel Daze'.

"Sudhanshu told police that he was a student of Delhi University and running seven PGs in the vicinity. He said he completed his graduation in 2019 and, since

2022, he had been operating PG accommodations in the Satya Niketan area with Tyagi," the officer said. The duo had taken four floors of the building on lease in August 2025 for a monthly rent of Rs 1.05 lakh. They took the property on rent at comparatively lower rates due to its dilapidated condition, he added.

Police sources said building owner Hariram Gupta had rented out the property, which was later handed over to Shubham Tyagi and Sudhanshu to run a PG from August 2025 despite its dilapidated condition.

Police said Sudhanshu remained indifferent to the construction work being carried out despite knowing

that it could affect the entire building.

Investigators are now probing how many students used to stay in the PG, its layout and the number of rooms in the building. Police are also procuring rent agreements signed by students with the owners and operators of the house to ascertain the accommodation arrangements and conditions imposed on the tenants. The rent agreement under which the PG was being operated has already come under scrutiny. According to a purported copy of the agreement, the PG owner had stated that he would not be responsible for any "casualties or risk" to tenants.

LG directs DDA to identify land for safe, affordable student housing



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday directed the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to identify suitable land parcels for student accommodations and engage with university officials for developing hostel facilities.

Sandhu, in a post on X, said he met DDA officials at Lok Niwas to review options for alternative accommodation facilities.

"Directed DDA to expedite identification of suitable land parcels for PGs (paying guests), prepare an actionable plan, and engage with university officials on provisions of the new Master Plan for developing hostel facilities," he said.

The development comes in the aftermath of the collapse of a boys' PG in Satya Niketan on Sunday, in which seven people were killed and five injured.

"Our focus is to ensure students have access to safe, affordable and dignified accommodation in Delhi," he added.

BCom student killed in building collapse, father alleges DU silence



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandauli (UP)

A BCom student from here was among the seven people killed in the building collapse in Delhi's Sathya Niketan, with his grieving father on Wednesday alleging that no official from Delhi University contacted the family.

Abhishek Kharwar, who was pursuing BCom in Motilal Nehru College, was staying in a paying guest (PG) accommodation in Satya Niketan, around two kilometres from his college, his father Santosh Kharwar said.

Since the college did not provide hostel accommodation, the family had arranged a rented room for him. Three days after the incident on September 6, the Chandauli sub-divisional magistrate (SDM) and a lekhpal visited the family home on Wednesday and offered condolences. They assured the family of all possible Government assistance.

"Abhishek was also a student of Delhi University, but despite such a big tragedy, no responsible offi-

cial from the university reached the spot or contacted us till now," Santosh said.

Abhishek had secured admission in August last year, his father said.

"We never felt that there was any danger in staying there," Santosh said, adding that most PG buildings in the area were around 20 to 25 years old.

Santosh said he reached Delhi around 10 am the day after the collapse.

Abhishek, who studied in English-medium schools, aspired to become a chartered accountant and was preparing for its examination alongside his graduation, his father said.

Abhishek was taken to AIIMS after he pulled out of the debris following the incident. Doctors told the family that Abhishek remained alive while he was trapped until around 9.15 pm on September 6, but later died, Santosh said.

Regarding the cause of death, he said the family was informed that the AIIMS report would be available only after 20-21 days, leaving

them without clarity on the exact cause of death for now.

The family donated Abhishek's eyes on September 8 before bringing his body to Varanasi, where his last rites were performed at Manikarnika Ghat, he said.

Abhishek's mother remained inconsolable since learning of her son's death, Santosh said. Abhishek was the younger of their two sons.

Santosh urged the Government to ensure hostel facilities in all Delhi University colleges where such accommodation is currently unavailable.

He also demanded an inspection of all PG buildings housing students, saying that those found to pose a safety risk should not be permitted to accommodate students on rent.

The collapse occurred around 1 pm on September 6 while repaired work was underway.

The structure, comprising a ground floor and four upper floors, housed several students and other residents.

LG orders police outreach to PG students, report in 11 days

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

For years, the students who fill Delhi's PGs and rented rooms have been mostly invisible to the police, present in the city's crime data only after something has already gone wrong. That is about to change, at least on paper. Following directions from Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, Delhi Police has ordered its Station House Officers and Assistant Commissioners of Police to start showing up in person, listening to student concerns before they turn into emergencies, not after.

The order, issued on Wednesday, comes after the LG stressed the need to strengthen police outreach and build confidence within the student community, particularly in areas packed with colleges, universities, PGs and rented accommodations. Police have been told



Officials inspect student paying guest (PG) accommodations in the Satya Niketan area following the collapse of a multi-storey building in New Delhi on Wednesday

to begin structured, proactive interactions with students at the local level immediately, and to submit an Action Taken Report by September 20.

Under the order, SHOs and ACSPs in areas with a heavy concentration of educational institutions and student housing have been directed to hold regular interactions with college students and those living in PGs or rented rooms within their jurisdiction.

During these interactions, officers have been told to do

four specific things: listen to and identify students' security and safety concerns, assess local issues around crime, harassment, women's safety and accommodation related problems, take prompt corrective and preventive action wherever the matter falls within local police powers, and coordinate with other civic agencies whenever an issue needs their intervention instead.

The order stresses that this cannot become a box-ticking exercise. Police have been told to carry it out in a

purposeful and responsive manner, with the real goal being direct communication between local police and students, and greater confidence that police help is actually available and accessible when needed.

The LG has also directed that the initiative be publicised through official social media and other channels as a genuine outreach effort toward college students and young people living in PGs and rented accommodations. But the order is specific on one point: the publicity must reflect real field-work and meaningful follow-up, not a photo opportunity dressed up as reform.

The timing of the directive is hard to separate from recent events. The order comes days after a building housing a boys' PG in Satya Niketan collapsed, killing seven people and reviving long-standing concerns over the safety of student accommodation across the city.

BJP MLA Anil Sharma denies AAP's illegal PG allegations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP MLA Anil Kumar Sharma on Wednesday rejected allegations by AAP that he owns and protects illegal PG accommodations in Satya Niketan. He called the claims baseless and threatened legal action for defamation, even as AAP demanded an investigation into his properties in the area.

Sharma, who represents RK Puram, expressed condolences over the deaths in the Satya Niketan building collapse and urged parties not to politicise the tragedy.



Addressing specific allegations, he said a photograph shown by the Opposition described a building as five-storey, claiming it would be demolished under Chief

Minister Rekha Gupta's orders. Sharma said the structure actually has still parking along with ground, first, second and third floors, with no fourth floor, and demanded an apology if the description was found incorrect, warning he would pursue defamation proceedings if necessary.

On allegations of land encroachment, Sharma said he possessed duly registered documents, a sale deed and a map clearly showing the property's address, asserting the land had been in his family for generations and was not encroached. He also said he had a copy of a

Lokayukta order concerning him and was ready to make it public. Regarding his residence, he said it comprises ground, first and second floors, with only two permitted servant rooms above.

Sharma called for scrutiny of Opposition leaders' own properties, saying the rules should apply equally to everyone. Earlier, addressing a press conference at AAP headquarters, Burari MLA Sanjeev Jha alleged that a viral video from Satya Niketan showed a woman claiming illegal PG operations in the area were running under Sharma's protection.

IN FOCUS



People row boats in a waterbody in Sangli, Maharashtra on Wednesday PTI

Baby orangutans baffle Odisha

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhubaneswar

A day after at least five orangutans were rescued from a forest in Odisha's Balasore district, a joint probe was launched by the state police's STF and the WCCB on suspicion that an international wildlife smuggling racket might be behind the animals' sudden appearance here.

State Forest and Environment Minister Ganesh Ram Singhkhuntia on Wednesday said the joint probe by the Special Task Force (STF) and the Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB) would look into how the animals came to Balasore, who brought them to the forest and who was involved in such activities.

Given the high value of the animals -- an orangutan can fetch Rs 20-25 lakh in international markets -- it is suspected that they were smuggled from foreign forests, he said.

The minister said orangutans are not found in India and are native to rainforests in Malaysia and Indonesia, including the islands of Borneo and Sumatra in Southeast Asia.

The animals were rescued and kept in quarantine at the Nandankanan Zoological Park in Bhubaneswar.



At least five orangutans were rescued by forest officials from Bichitrapur forest area under Bhograi block, in Balasore district, Odisha, Tuesday, Sept. 8, 2026. The orangutans are not native to India, prompting the Forest Department to investigate how they arrived in the area. PTI

"A team of veterinary doctors are monitoring the health of the animals, and they are stable. I will visit them today. These rare animals are kept in an air-conditioned atmosphere," the minister said.

Odisha STF Inspector General Himansu Lal said a team led by an SP-rank officer had already left for Balasore and started a probe into the matter.

"We are at the preliminary stage of investigation and presently collecting data and facts available locally. We are in contact with the

central government's IG, wildlife, and seeking to know whether a similar incident had ever happened in any part of the country," STF DIG Vishal Singh said.

The STF team contacted the Balasore district SP and DFO and collected details regarding the rescue of the rare animals from a casuarina forest in the Bichitrapur area of Bhograi block in Balasore district.

Meanwhile, forest officials and local police went door to door to collect information regarding the incident. Villagers first spotted the

young apes clinging to trees on Tuesday morning and immediately alerted the forest department, Balasore Divisional Forest Officer Prateek Prakash Indalkar said.

Local people have so far reported seeing a black SUV on a road near the forest on Monday night. The vehicle was also spotted in CCTV footage.

"Therefore, locating the SUV and its owner could give some clue to the arrival of the baby orangutans in Balasore," a local police officer said.

Delhi draws battle plan for winter smog



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Winter has not yet arrived in Delhi, but the city's air already has an appointment book. Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta sat down on Wednesday with a map of 47 pollution hotspots, 13 senior officers, and a demand that has failed the city every year for a decade: make this winter different.

The high-level review, attended by ministers Ashish Sood, Manjinder Sira and Pankaj Kumar Singh, along with the Chief Secretary, the MCD Commissioner, the CEO of Delhi Jal Board and heads of PWD, DDA, transport and environment departments,

focused on the sources that choke the capital every year without fail: dust from roads and construction sites, vehicle exhaust, industrial emissions and open burning.

Metro construction dust emerged as an early flash-point, with the Chief Minister and the Environment Minister flagging it as a major concern. Officials explained that bitumen-based road repair had been delayed for months because of supply disruptions linked to the situation in West Asia, which had made bitumen scarce. With supplies now normalising, repair work on both bitumen and cement concrete roads is being pushed to finish as soon as possible.

Oxygen cylinder blast in Okhla kills one, injures four

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The owner of the commercial godown in Delhi's Okhla Phase-I was detained on Wednesday after an industrial oxygen cylinder explosion left one person dead and four others injured. The cylinder exploded in the morning after it fell onto the road while being unloaded from a truck, police said.

According to eyewitnesses, the blast was powerful enough to shatter glass windows of nearby buildings.

The deceased was identified as Mohit Singh (35), a helper working with a company which operates from Okhla Phase-I. He was a

resident of Jaitpur in Delhi and had reportedly been working with the firm for around three years, police said.

The injured were identified as Umesh, Arvind, Manoj and Pankaj. They were immediately rushed to the AIIMS Trauma Centre for treatment.

Police filed an FIR under section 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of the BNS, following which the owner was detained.

According to officials, a PCR call regarding the blast was received at 10.45 am, following which police and fire department teams reached the spot and secured the area.

Three water tenders and a multi-casualty first respon-



Forensic officials at the site after an oxygen cylinder exploded while it was being unloaded from a truck at a commercial godown in southeast Delhi's Okhla Phase-I PTI

der vehicle were also rushed to the site.

A preliminary police inquiry found that the labourers were working for a firm engaged in

trading and local distribution of industrial oxygen cylinders, which were intended for medical purposes and gas-cutting work.

In a statement, the firm's manager said the vehicle carrying the cylinders arrived at the premises in the morning, as part of the firm's routine operations. The workers were unloading the cylinders and shifting them inside the godown when one of the cylinders fell onto the road.

"An immediate explosion followed. Preliminary inquiry suggests that only one cylinder exploded. The exact technical cause of the blast has not yet been established. The scene, the cylinder, the vehicle and other relevant material will be examined by technical and forensic agencies to determine the precise cause of the explosion," a police officer said.

Delhi airport files FIR against 63 handles

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Delhi airport operator DIAL on Wednesday said it has filed an FIR against 63 social media handles for circulating misleading content regarding flooding and waterlogging at the airport last week.

On September 4, 2026, the arrival forecourt of the airport's Terminal 3 witnessed temporary water accumulation following heavy rainfall.

DIAL said it has lodged a First Information Report (FIR) with the Delhi Police against 63 social media handles for circulating misleading and factually incorrect posts



depicting flooding and waterlogging at the airport and falsely suggesting disruption to airport operations.

"... in one of these posts,

an old video of waterlogging at Dubai airport was claimed to be a video of Delhi airport," DIAL said in a statement.

While there was temporary water accumulation in the T3 arrival forecourt following an episode of heavy rainfall, DIAL said airport operations were not affected, and the situation was resolved within 20 minutes.

"The circulation of misleading content by certain social media handles appears to be a deliberate attempt to create public mischief, damage the reputation of a public utility service, and generate unwarranted concerns among passengers," it said.

Delhi orders bulldozer action

The MCD surveyed a total of 1,252 PG buildings across the city. Of these, 39 buildings were found to require minor repair, while nine buildings required major repair. Three buildings were found to be dangerous, and one of these three has already been demolished, according to the records. The demolition actions in some parts, however, drew allegations from local residents who claimed that enforcement was selective, with similar multi-storey structures allegedly continuing to operate in the area without facing comparable action. The MCD has directed its field staff to step up inspections of unsafe and dilapidated buildings and ensure that construction is carried out in accordance with sanctioned building plans and safety norms.

In an order issued by the deputy commissioner of the MCD's North West Zone, junior engineers were asked to ensure that owners and builders adhere to sanctioned plans and take all precautions prescribed under the Unified Building Bye-Laws, 2016, and the Master Plan for Delhi. The order noted that Delhi had witnessed several building collapses in recent times and said the survey of dangerous buildings falls under the mandate of the Building Department. Junior engineers have been directed to conduct fresh surveys in unauthorised areas to identify structures that have become dilapidated or outlived their structural life.

The five-storey building that collapsed in Satya Niketan is the fifth in the city this year. According to official figures and police statements, the 16 deaths have come from three incidents -- six in Saket in May, three in Rohini in July and seven in the latest incident on September 6. The underlying factors leading to the collapse of all the buildings are common, said officials. These include unregulated and unauthorised construction, additional floors, ageing structures and a lack of structural assessments.

Cognizant hit by US visa crackdown

D'Esposito added that the investigation into the two companies was conducted in coordination with the White House Fraud Task Force and other officials.

"Fighting fraud is a TEAM SPORT. @Sonderling47 and I are for real. @Cognizant's PERM filings are suspended. @DOLOIG is on the hunt," D'Esposito said, referring to Keith Sonderling, Acting Secretary, Department of Labour.

"Alongside @WHFraudTF, we're following facts, fraud and finances. Handcuffs await," D'Esposito said.

PERM, or Program Electronic Review

Management, is the process through which US employers seek approval from the Department of Labour to sponsor foreign workers for permanent residency.

As part of the process, employers generally must demonstrate that no qualified and available US workers exist for the position and that hiring a foreign worker will not adversely affect the wages or working conditions of American workers.

In July, the Trump administration launched a major investigation into alleged fraud involving the H-1B and PERM employment visa programmes. Cognizant was founded in Chennai in 1994 and now has its headquarters in Teaneck, New Jersey. As of June 30, Cognizant received approvals for 3,510 H-1B visa petitions, compared to 9,413 in 2020, according to data shared by the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). (PTI)

NIA nabs PNB manager in fake currency case

A preliminary check, followed by a full audit by teams from the Reserve Bank of India and PNB, found large amounts of fake ₹500 notes. The issue started with a shortfall in a remittance sent to the RBI's Jaipur office, but it quickly became a bigger discovery. At first, officials found about ₹7.4 crore in suspected fake notes, but as they kept checking, the total rose to ₹17.29 crore. Investigators believe the genuine notes may have been removed and replaced with counterfeits over time.

The first inquiry suggested that three PNB employees were involved. Along with Kumar, the group includes Ravi Kumar Kanse, the senior divisional manager, and Sushil Kumar, the manager of the Saharanpur currency chest, who is also listed as Sushil Sharma in records. The bank has suspended all three.

Because of the large amount of fake currency found and the possibility that a bigger network was involved, the Ministry of Home Affairs handed over the investigation to the NIA. The agency re-registered the case on September 3 as RC-02/2026/NIA/LKW at its Lucknow branch. CCTV footage from the investigation reportedly showed a part-time housekeeper taking notes from currency bundles inside the chest, raising further suspicion of insider involvement.

The NIA has taken electronic devices and documents from the homes of the suspended officials and is now checking call records and movement patterns. Agency officials say the investigation is now focused on finding out where the fake notes came from, how they got into the secure currency chest, where any real cash may have gone, and who else might be involved, including any cross-border links.

FROM PAGE - 1

Govt clears major railway expansion

These corridors connect many major cities in the country. The Delhi-Howrah route includes major stations such as Kanpur, Prayagraj, Pt. Deendayal Upadhyay, Patna, and Asansol. Vaishnav also said that enhanced rail network will add on passengers trains and the idea is to complete overcome the situation of issuing of waitlisted travel tickets and that traveller can travel as per their choice of time and trains.

The Delhi-Mumbai route connects cities such as Mathura, Kota, Ratlam, Vadodara, and Surat. The Delhi-Chennai route connects cities such as Agra, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Nagpur, and Vijayawada. The Mumbai-Chennai route includes several important areas, including Pune.

PM Modi led Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) also approved several railway multi-tracking projects worth around Rs 11,000 crore across five states. These multi-tracking proposals are poised to streamline operations and alleviate congestion on some of the country's busiest rail routes. The projects are planned under the PM-Gati Shakti National Master Plan with a focus on enhancing multi-modal connectivity and logistics efficiency through integrated planning and stakeholder consultations.

The proposed projects are essential routes for transportation of commodities such as coal, cement, iron and steel, etc. The capacity augmentation works will result in additional freight traffic of magnitude 27 MTPA (Million Tonnes Per Annum).

Crypto platforms face crack down

Most of the companies named are mid-sized or offshore exchanges and swap services, not the biggest global brands that already work with Indian regulators. Many retail traders use these platforms for derivatives, instant swaps or easy-to-use features.

VDA SPs operating in India, whether offshore or onshore, and engaged in activities like exchange of virtual digital assets and fiat currencies, and transfer of virtual digital assets, are required to be registered with FIU-IND as reporting entity and comply with Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). These obligations are activity-based and are not contingent on physical presence of the entity in India.

Registered companies have to keep records, check customer backgrounds, monitor transactions, and send reports to FIU-IND.

Users may have trouble withdrawing their funds from these platforms. The Government has not said anything about compensation or ways for users to recover assets affected by these actions. The Ministry of Finance has issued a general warning. It said crypto products and non-

fungible tokens are still unregulated in India and can be risky.

Delhi turns into a diplomatic fortress...

The main hotels are reportedly booked out through Monday, while room rates at other five-star properties have climbed sharply, with some rooms costing up to ₹40,000.

Hotel kitchens are getting ready to meet the individual preferences of visiting delegations. According to a senior official, some countries that had previously travelled with their own chefs are now opting to use Indian culinary teams. Some delegations have reportedly even requested particular chefs by name.

Several of Delhi's high-profile restaurants, including Bukhara, Dum Pukht, House of Ming, Varq, Jamavar, Megu, 360, Baoshuan, Loya and Spicy Duck, are also preparing for possible visits by VVIP guests.

The hotels will also serve as temporary communication hubs for foreign delegations.

Large suites separate from the leaders' presidential accommodation are being converted into communication centres. These facilities will allow officials to hold meetings and maintain secure communication with their respective capitals during the summit. The arrangement is designed to give visiting governments a secure operational base while their leaders attend official engagements in Delhi.

The summit is also set to draw an enormous international media presence. The Ministry of External Affairs expects between 1,200 and 1,300 journalists each day at the International Media Centre inside Bharat Mandapam. Indian and international journalists are expected to be represented in broadly equal numbers, with around 600 to 700 journalists from each side. India has also used its BRICS presidency to broaden its diplomatic outreach. Indian missions and consulates abroad have been promoting the presidency in local languages, while dedicated BRICS social-media accounts and a website have been launched to provide information about events throughout the year.

More than 350 BRICS-related meetings have already been held at different locations across India during the country's 2026 presidency. The September 12-13 summit will bring that year-long programme to its high point - and put Delhi's ability to manage one of the world's biggest diplomatic gatherings under an intense spotlight.

BJP to launch month-long drive on PM's...

"When he (Modi) took over the leadership of the country, India was facing policy paralysis and was being referred to as one of the 'fragile five'

economies. Today, India is the fastest-growing major economy in the world. India's stature and standing on the global stage have also risen significantly," he said.

More than 37 countries have conferred their highest honours on Modi, the BJP chief said, adding that the recognition is a reflection of the respect for 140 crore Indians.

As part of the 'Seva Sankalp Abhiyan', a major programme will be held on October 7, when Modi will complete 25 years in public office, Nabin said. 'Seva Jyoti Kalash Yatra' programmes will be organised in all district headquarters, with 'padayatras', motorcycle and cycle rallies.

"A collective pledge for 'Viksit Bharat 2047' will also be taken in district headquarters and around 1,000 locations across the country on October 7," he added.

Nabin said the BJP will organise painting, drawing and speech competitions in schools between September 17 and October 7 on Modi's 25 years of public service and the vision of a 'Viksit Bharat'. Winners will be awarded certificates at the level of chief ministers and Union ministers, he said.

Under 'Namo Seva Ankahi Kahaniyan', stories of people whose lives have changed through government welfare schemes will be presented through music, theatre and street plays and taken to villages, the BJP chief said.

Under 'Seva Ki Kahani', beneficiaries will be given a platform to share stories of how government schemes changed their lives, he said. The BJP will also organise two youth-led 'Seva Yatras' between Modi's birthplace Vadnagar and his 'karmabhoomi' Varanasi. Ten teams will travel from Vadnagar to Varanasi and another 10 from Varanasi to Vadnagar, with around 1,000 youths taking part.

The 20-day yatras will pass through 10 states and include interactions with villagers, farmers, Anganwadi workers, youth clubs and students, besides discussions on welfare schemes and collection of public feedback, Nabin said.

Under 'Seva Mera Yogdan', people will be encouraged to contribute at least 25 minutes of 'shramdaan' across 25 themes. 'Seva Setu' camps will also be organised at the block level to help eligible beneficiaries access welfare schemes. Health camps and information camps on government schemes will also be held.

Under 'Seva Ke Rang, Rashtra Ke Sang', human rangolis will be created at prominent public places to showcase welfare schemes and the message of 'Viksit Bharat', with participation from artists, women self-help groups, students and the public. The BJP will also organise a 'Seva First Innovation Challenge' for the youth, students, start-ups, professionals and corporate innovators. The BJP will also organise a cleanliness drive on October 2 as part of the campaign.

2-day BRICS summit starts Saturday, focus on food, energy resilience

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The two-day BRICS summit hosted by India starting Saturday will focus on boosting collective resilience in food, energy, health, disaster reduction and critical supply chains — positioning the group as an effective anchor to navigate a fragmented geopolitical environment.

The summit in New Delhi is taking place against the backdrop of the global economy facing the adverse impacts of the Russia-Ukraine war, the West Asia crisis, especially the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, and the Trump administration's trade and tariff policies.

Chinese President Xi Jinping, Iranian President

Masoud Pezeshkian, Russian President Vladimir Putin, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto are among the top leaders expected to attend the crucial meeting.

With just three days left for the summit, it remains unclear whether the member nations of the grouping reached consensus on a joint statement, as differences between Iran and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) over the West Asia crisis persist.

The grouping operates under a framework of consensus. BRICS, originally comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the United Arab Emirates and



Vehicles ply on a road near the illuminated Bharat Mandapam amid preparations ahead of the BRICS Summit in New Delhi on Wednesday PTI

Saudi Arabia, with Indonesia joining in 2025.

Belarus, Bolivia, Kazakhstan, Cuba, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Uganda,

Uzbekistan and Vietnam became BRICS partner countries last year.

BRICS emerged as an influential grouping as it brings

together 11 major emerging economies of the world, representing around 49.5 per cent of the global population, around 40 per cent of the global GDP and around 26 per cent of the global trade.

India's chairship of the grouping centred on the four pillars: resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability.

Under the resilience pillar, India has been focusing on strengthening collective cooperation in areas such as health, agriculture, food, energy, disaster risk reduction and supply chains, officials said.

Enhancing cooperation in trade, investment, connectivity and high technology will also be high on the agenda of the summit, they said.

India's BRICS chairship is

guided by the theme: 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability', reflecting its vision of a people-centric approach rooted in the spirit of "humanity first."

In addition to these areas, the leaders will exchange views on strengthening intra-BRICS cooperation on common priorities and share perspectives on global and regional matters of mutual importance, according to the Ministry of External Affairs.

Under India's Chairship this year, over 350 meetings and high-level engagements have been held in over 25 cities across the country to further strengthen the BRICS strategic partnership across three fundamental pillars: political and security, eco-

nomc and financial, and cultural and people-to-people exchanges.

India is a founding member of BRICS and has previously held its chairship in 2012, 2016 and 2021. India assumed its fourth BRICS chairship on January 1, 2026.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), the summit will begin at 2.35 pm on Saturday with a closed-door session for BRICS member countries themed "Inclusive Global Governance and Strengthening Multilateralism".

Following the session, leaders will tour the "Bharat Innovates Exhibition", scheduled to open at 4.25 pm. At 5.05 pm, the leaders will assemble on the lawns of Bharat Mandapam — the

summit venue — for a family photo, followed by a joint tree-planting ceremony.

The first day's engagements will conclude with a gala dinner hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at 7.30 pm. On Sunday, leaders from BRICS member states, partner nations and outreach invitees will arrive starting at 9.55 am, followed by an official group photo at 10.35 am.

The open session, titled "Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability: Shaping the Future for Inclusive Global Growth", is scheduled to begin at 10.50 am, according to the schedule released by the MEA.

The summit will culminate with the release of the New Delhi Declaration.

Nabin sounds poll bugle in Uttarakhand, attacks Congress, Mallikarjun Kharge over purification

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Haldwani

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Wednesday rallied party workers, urging them to gear up for the upcoming Assembly polls with full strength and unity, asserting that the coming decade will belong to Uttarakhand.

Addressing the workers here, Nabin said that 'Devbhoomi' of Uttarakhand would continue to progress under the BJP leadership and exuded confidence that the party would register a massive victory in the State election in 2027.

"This decade will belong to Uttarakhand," Nabin said.

He called upon party workers to take the achievements of the central and state governments to the masses and to strengthen the organisation at the booth level. Nabin also accused Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge of engaging in divisive politics and hatching political conspiracies "even in Uttarakhand, a land known for penance and spiritual devotion."

"The State of Uttarakhand was formed under the leadership of former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Today,



the central Government led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi has strengthened the road network right up to the country's borders and prioritised national security," Nabin said.

He also accused the Congress of consistently insulting Dalits during its tenure. His remarks come against the backdrop of Congress's demand for an FIR against people responsible for the

"purification" of a venue in Haldwani after Kharge, a Dalit, gave a speech there.

The local police on Tuesday filed an FIR against unknown persons under sections 196 and 299 of the BNS, as well as Section 3(1)(r) of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, based on a complaint of Congress leader and advocate Anju Arya at the Haldwani Police Station.

Congress alleges income tax evasion scam through unrecognised political parties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Wednesday attacked the Modi Government, alleging a ₹10,000 crore income tax evasion "scam" involving unrecognised political parties and demanded a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) probe into it.

There was no immediate reaction from Government to the allegations.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh asked who was the "Chanakya" behind the 3,260 "sham political parties" and who was the "true mastermind" of the alleged scam.

"The Modi Government must answer to the nation," Ramesh said in a post in Hindi on X.

"Prime Minister (Narendra Modi), you failed to bring back black money from abroad, and citizens have yet to receive the promised ₹15 lakh each; yet, it now appears that a scheme to launder black money — turning it 'white' — is under way right here in the country under the BJP's patronage," he said.

Ramesh asked why, despite cases of tax evasion and money laundering through fake political parties coming to light, the Government had not taken action against the alleged tax evaders and such parties.

He said Congress colleague Shaktisinh Gohil had questioned the Government's failure to impose 200 per cent penalties and initiate criminal proceedings against those guilty, despite the alleged revelation of tax evasion exceeding ₹10,000 crore involving 3,260 Registered Unrecognised Political Parties (RUPPs).

"We recall how, just before the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the Congress party — India's principal opposition — had its bank accounts frozen and was slapped with massive tax notices in a highly undemocratic move aimed at financially crippling the party," Ramesh said. "So, why is there no investigation into these 3,260 sham political parties and the associated cases of tax evasion?" he asked.

"Is it because these fraudulent parties enjoyed the patronage of the BJP leadership and were orchestrating this entire scam with the Government's tacit approval?" he alleged.

Addressing a press conference, Gohil claimed that there were 3,260 Registered



Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh

Unrecognised Political Parties (RUPPs) in the country being used to evade income tax.

He said Section 80GGC of the Income Tax Act states that if an individual donates the amount they owe in income tax to a political party, it becomes zero, while the other section, 80GGD states that if a company donates its tax money to any registered political party, its tax also becomes zero.

"The scam now is that these 3,260 RUPPs have collected donations worth around ₹10,000 crore," he alleged. Gohil said that when an NGO report came out in 2025, it was the Government's responsibility to take action, but no action was taken. He said the Government had stated that

donations to those found guilty should be rejected and they should not be given any benefits from them.

"Whereas, according to the law, against those committing fraud, a 200 per cent penalty should be imposed on fake companies; criminal cases should be filed against them, and upon being found guilty, they should face seven years in jail. But in this case, no action has been taken against even a single person yet," Gohil said.

He alleged that chartered accountants had a major role in tax evasion scams and said income tax officers had explicitly stated that action should be taken against such CAs. "But no orders for any such action have come from 'above', because these are their own 'C team'. The

Income Tax Appellate Tribunal has said that such tax evasion is fatal for the country. This black money will weaken the country's economy and security," Gohil said. He alleged that the Modi Government was shielding its "own people" from action.

Gohil said the Election Commission had guidelines on transparency and accountability in political funding and that election officers in every state were responsible for scrutinising donations and expenditures of political parties.

He also questioned whether the Election Commission was "in collusion with the BJP", while noting that such a question had never previously been raised against the poll panel as it was an autonomous body. "Previously, the appointment of the CEC was done jointly by the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition, and the Chief Justice of India," he said.

"Narendra Modi removed the Chief Justice of India from the CEC appointment process and replaced them with another central minister, who is Amit Shah.

Now, Narendra Modi and Amit Shah will jointly appoint as CEC only those who obey their word," he alleged.

NC, Congress clash over playing full Vande Mataram in J&K

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

A fresh war of words broke out on Wednesday between alliance partners National Conference and Congress after the full six-stanza version of Vande Mataram was played at an official State event in Srinagar, with Chief Minister Omar Abdullah and NC president Farooq Abdullah standing through the entire rendition.

The national song was first played at the inauguration of the International Film Festival of Jammu and Kashmir (IFFJK) at the Sher-e-Kashmir International Convention Centre on Monday. Both Abdullahs stood at attention for the complete version. On

Wednesday, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah stood respectfully at attention for the full rendition of the national song, "Vande Mataram," during the oath ceremony of the Chief Justice of the Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court.

Congress, which extends outside support to the NC-led Government in the Union Territory and is part of the INDIA bloc with the NC nationally, objected and asked its ally to stick to the two-stanza version adopted by the party in 1937 and reaffirmed by the Congress Working Committee last month.

Hitting back, the National Conference (NC) said it was a "statutory obligation" to play the full national song at



NC chief spokesperson Tanveer Sadiq, Congress leader KC Venugopal

a State event and that no one would be forced to sing. Responding to the criticism, NC chief spokesperson Tanveer Sadiq told reporters in Srinagar that Government protocol must be separated from party ideology.

"The National Conference has a clear stance. When

Parliament has adopted it, playing Vande Mataram becomes a statutory obligation, and that is what the Government did," Sadiq said.

Chief ministers in non-BJP states like Telangana and Karnataka have also played the complete version of Vande Mataram at official

functions, he said.

"As far as the party's stand is concerned, anyone who wants to sing Vande Mataram can do so, and no one will be forced," he added. Earlier, on Tuesday, Congress general secretary (Organisation) KC Venugopal posted a video of the IFFJK on X, asserting that the unabridged version of Vande Mataram "sits uneasily with the syncretic and pluralist ethos that our freedom fighters envisioned and nurtured for India".

He urged alliance partners to honour the Congress' historical 1937 working committee resolution, which adopted a truncated version of the song to respect India's religious diversity and conscience.

Meta officials appear before NCPCR over alleged child sexual abuse materials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior executives of global social media giant Meta, which runs Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp, appeared before the child rights body NCPCR on Wednesday in connection with its inquiry into alleged advertisements related to child sexual exploitative and abuse material (CSEAM) on the platform.

Details about the questioning were not immediately available. The National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) had on July 3 taken suo motu cognisance of a media report by BBC Eye regarding alleged advertisements related to CSEAM and sought an explanation from Meta Platforms, Inc. Meta submitted its response to the commission a week later.

NCPCR subsequently decided to institute an inquiry



to determine the facts of the matter and in continuation of the same, summoned the MD and Head of Meta India to appear before it on Wednesday, officials said. The commission's move comes amid concerns over the alleged availability and promotion of child sexual exploitation material through online platforms. In July, the Government issued a stern notice to Meta on CSEAM in paid advertisements on Instagram. The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) had ordered Instagram to disable all ads and content promoting and facilitating access to

CSEAM and also demanded a detailed explanation on it.

The action came after IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw directed MeitY officials to summon Meta over Instagram ads allegedly promoting child sexual abuse material. The regulatory scrutiny from the ministry came amid a BBC report that alleged Meta's recommendation algorithm had been promoting videos containing child sexual abuse material, exposing serious gaps in the safeguards.

The BBC investigation had also allegedly found advertisements of this nature appearing on Facebook and Instagram, despite Meta's advertising policies explicitly prohibiting nudity and sexually explicit content.

Instagram is alleged to have shown paid advertisements with terms like "rape video" and "child video", which directed users to Telegram channels where such content was reportedly on sale.

India sends fresh tranche of relief material to Nepal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India on Wednesday sent a fresh tranche of humanitarian aid comprising 35 tonnes of relief material and equipment onboard a C-17 transport aircraft to flood-ravaged Nepal, officials said.

The death toll from the devastating flash floods in Nepal climbed to 1,365 on Wednesday as more bodies were recovered from the affected areas, according to authorities.

The first tranche of relief

material was sent by India hours after Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to his Nepalese counterpart Balendra Shah on August 26, the day flash floods struck the Himalayan nation.

Since then, New Delhi has sent multiple consignments, including relief supplies and essential medicines, besides deploying an Indian tunnel rescue team, who are continuing to work alongside the Nepalese Army, and a forensic team to aid in the identification of mortal remains of the victims.

Several MPs raise concerns over Indian Statistical Institute Bill



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Several MPs on Wednesday questioned a Government bill that proposes to widen the remit of the Indian Statistical Institute, claiming it will reduce the premier institute's autonomy.

At a meeting of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance, headed by BJP MP Bhartuhari Mahtab, members raised concerns about the Indian Statistical Institute Bill, 2026, and sought its minute examination. The committee met for the first time to discuss the Bill, with many of them questioning the Government's move as they feel that the proposed law may reduce the autonomy of the Indian Statistical Institute, sources aware of the deliberations said. The Bill was introduced in Lok Sabha in the Monsoon session of Parliament. At the time of its introduction, many MPs raised their objections.

Subsequently, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla referred the Bill to the parliamentary committee for threadbare examination.

The committee was given three months to submit the report. However, sources on

Wednesday said the Bill will take a much longer period than the sanctioned time.

The Bill seeks the institute's incorporation as a 'body corporate' to strengthen its governance, promote academic excellence and research, and allow it to serve emerging needs in the field of statistics and allied fields.

The Bill says the President of India will be the Visitor of the institute and the provisions for a Board of Governors will be its principal policy executive body.

The board will be headed by a chairperson, who will be an eminent person from the field of academia, industry, education, public policy, and statistical sciences.

The board will be accountable to the central Government, the bill notes.

The institute will have an Academic Council, which will act as its principal academic body, and it will be headed by the institute's director.

All full-time professors and full-time faculty will be members of the Academic Council. The Indian Statistical Institute Act, 1959, declared the institute to be an institution of national importance and empowered it to grant degrees and diplomas in sta-

tistics. The Act was amended in 1995 to empower the Institute to grant degrees and diplomas in statistics, mathematics, quantitative economics, computer science and such other subjects related to statistics as may be determined by it from time to time. The 1959 Act, according to the proposed bill, has limited provisions in respect of the governance, administration, finance, accountability and functioning of the Institute and is not adequate to enable it to respond to the requirements of an evolving academic and research environment. Therefore, it says, the Government decided to repeal the Indian Statistical Institute Act, 1959, to bring out comprehensive legislation providing for the incorporation of the Indian Statistical Institute, an institution of national importance, to excel as a globally recognised centre in Statistical Sciences and allied fields.

The legal reform will enable an ecosystem to train a new generation of high-quality data scientists and statisticians, bridging the massive talent gap currently facing India's tech and financial sectors, the Bill says.



States Focus



ARUNACHAL INTEGRAL TO INDIA'S UNITY: VP RADHAKRISHNAN

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Wednesday said Arunachal Pradesh was integral to India's unity, with the Northeast region, aided by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Act East policy, emerging as a key driver of the country's growth. Addressing a special session of the Arunachal Pradesh Legislative Assembly in Itanagar, he said the State stands as a "proud guardian" of India's borders, and its development is closely linked to the progress of the country.

He also said Arunachal Pradesh is culturally rich with "boundless potential". Radhakrishnan said the Northeast has been given increasing priority by successive Governments, recalling that former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee had created the Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER). (PTI)



EVERY FOURTH JAN DHAN ACCOUNT INACTIVE: GEHLOT

Former Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot on Wednesday claimed that every fourth bank account under the Jan Dhan Yojana was inactive, alleging that flawed policies of the Modi Government at the Centre have led to rising poverty in the country. In a statement, Gehlot said, "Every fourth account under the Jan Dhan Yojana is inactive, with 5.72 crore accounts not even having a single rupee. This is the real picture behind the Modi Government's claims of 'poor welfare'." Referring to an RTI reply on Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, the Congress leader said this was a clear indication that the Modi Government's wrong policies were increasing poverty in the country, leading to empty bank accounts, while a handful of the country's wealthy continued to grow richer. (PTI)

BJP received more than ₹1,473 crores in recent polls: ECI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The latest expenditure statements filed with the Election Commission show a major contrast between the finances of the BJP and the Congress during the recent Assembly elections. The BJP received nearly ₹1,473 crore at its central headquarters alone during the last five State Assembly elections—Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal and Puducherry — more than seven times the ₹207 crore in net receipts reported by the Congress across its Central and State units.

The contrast is even more striking because the BJP figure covers receipts at its central

headquarters alone. Its expenditure reports for Kerala and West Bengal are yet to be made public, which means that its consolidated receipts are likely to be higher. The two parties also emerged from the election period in sharply different financial positions. The BJP had ₹6,722.6 crore at its central headquarters when the election period began on March 15. By May 6, its closing balance had climbed to ₹7,627.2 crore. This is an increase of ₹904.6 crore during the poll period, while the Congress moved in the opposite direction.

The Congress, whose consolidated expenditure report for Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal and Puducherry had come earlier, reported net



receipts of ₹207.17 crore and an expenditure of ₹248.55 crore during the March 15-May 6 election period. The BJP's ₹1,472.8-crore figure, by contrast, represents receipts at its central headquarters alone during the same period, according to its expenditure statements made public by the ECI. The party's expendi-

ture reports for Kerala and West Bengal polls are yet to be made public, meaning its consolidated receipts are likely to be higher.

On the other hand, the Congress' finances saw a dip during the polls. Across its central headquarters and five state units, it began the election period with about ₹169.06

Bihar floods affect over 40 lakh people across 14 districts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

More than 40 lakh people have been affected by floods across 14 districts of Bihar following torrential rains over the past five days, with several rivers flowing above the danger mark, officials said on Wednesday.

"Incessant rain in various districts caused rivers and streams to overflow. Besides, heavy rainfall in catchment areas of Nepal has also led to rivers flowing above the danger level at several places," an official said.

According to a statement by the Disaster Management Department (DMD), around 40.21 lakh people in 514 gram panchayats across 84 blocks in 14 districts have been affected by floods. The affected districts are Patna, Bhojpur, Saran, Vaishali, Bhagalpur, Begusarai, Buxar, Samastipur, Munger, Katihar, Lakhisarai, Khagaria, Purnia and Arwal. According to the meteorological service centre, the state has record-



ed 79.6 mm of rainfall in September so far, which is 31 per cent above normal.

In its latest bulletin, the DMD said, "The Ganga at Sultanjanj in Bhagalpur recorded 36.78 metres at 9 am on September 9, surpassing its previous Highest Flood Level (HFL) of 36.75 metres recorded on August 17, 2021. The trend, however, remains stable."

Several rivers, including the Gandak, Kosi, Budhi Gandak, Ganga, Punpun, Bagmati and Ghaghra, are flowing above danger levels

at multiple locations, officials said. The water levels of the Gandak at Dumariya Ghat, Kosi at Baltara and Kursela, Burhi Gandak at Khagaria, and Ganga at Digha, Gandhi Ghat, Hathidah, Bhagalpur and Kahalgaon, as well as at Munger, Punpun at Sripalpur, Bagmati at Benibad, and Ghaghara at Darauli and Gangpur Siswan, are flowing above the danger mark.

A total of 723 community kitchens are currently being operated in various districts for flood-affected people. In addition, 15 relief camps

are being operated, where arrangements for accommodation, food, medical care and other essential facilities have been made for 13,446 flood evacuees, it said.

"So far, around 1.94 lakh polythene sheets and approximately 29,400 dry ration packets have been distributed among flood-hit people. To facilitate evacuation and transportation, a total of 1,979 boats are currently being operated. So far, 5,178 quintals of animal fodder have also been distributed", the bulletin said.

As far as the discharge of water from major barrages in the State is concerned, the statement said the Gandak Barrage recorded a discharge of 86,000 cusecs at 10 am on Wednesday, with a stable trend. The highest discharge recorded so far this year was 2,24,000 cusecs on July 14. The discharge at Kosi Barrage stood at 1,48,200 cusecs, with a stable trend, at 10 am. Its highest discharge so far this year was 2,55,425 cusecs on July 20.

BJP accuses Gujarat Congress MLA of insulting Vande Mataram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

The ruling BJP alleged that Congress MLA Imran Khedawala disrespected Vande Mataram by remaining seated during its rendition at the start of the Gujarat assembly's monsoon session on Wednesday and demanded an apology from him.

While the Opposition Congress denied the charge, State minister Pravin Mali alleged that Khedawala stood up when the national song began but immediately sat down. Khedawala, who represents the Jamalpur-Khadia seat in Ahmedabad, is the lone Muslim MLA in Gujarat.

The three-day monsoon session of the State Assembly began in Gandhinagar on Wednesday.

Speaking to reporters, Mali said there was a tradition of opening the session with Vande Mataram and alleged that Khedawala's conduct amounted to insulting the national song. "We demand an answer from the



Congress MLA Imran Khedawala

Congress for this insult; they should clarify whether this is Imran Khedawala's personal stand or what the party's official stand is," he said.

The minister demanded that Khedawala apologise for his conduct.

NESO condemns murder of Manipur musician in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Shillong

NESO on Wednesday condemned the killing of 54-year-old Manipuri musician Chongtham Vikram Singh in Southeast Delhi and demanded a swift and impartial probe into the incident.

Singh was beaten to death by a group of delivery workers and dhaba staff when he objected to their shouting and drinking alcohol outside his Kilokari village apartment early Monday.

North Eastern Students' Organisation (NESO) chairman Samuel B Jyrwa said the incident was deeply disturbing and demanded that all those responsible be brought to justice.

"It is deeply disturbing that a person can lose his life merely for raising an objection to disturbance outside his own home. We demand a transparent and impartial investigation and exemplary punishment for every person found responsible," Jyrwa said in a statement.

He said the killing cannot be viewed in isolation from the continuing harassment, racial discrimination, stereotyping, intimidation and violence faced by people from the Northeast in different parts of mainland India.

VHP's call to bar Muslims from garba unconstitutional: Athawale

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

Union minister Ramdas Athawale on Wednesday opposed calls to bar Muslims from attending 'garba' events during the Navratri festival, and said India is governed by the Constitution, which guarantees equal rights to people of all religions.

Asked about Vishva Hindu Parishad's call to bar Muslims from Navratri events in Maharashtra, Athawale said such a stand is not appropriate as people of different faiths have the right to participate in each other's festivals.

The Minister of State for Social Justice and Empowerment was talking to reporters at Swami Vivekananda Airport here after arriving on a day-long visit to Chhattisgarh.

"I feel this stand is not right because India runs on the Constitution. The Constitution given by Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar



Union minister Ramdas Athawale

ensures justice to all religions. Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs, Christians, Jains, Buddhists, Lingayats, Parsis and people of several other faiths live in India, and the Constitution seeks to protect all religions," he said.

"It is not good to say that Muslims should not attend garba. Hindu and Muslim communities need to come together and work for the country," said Athawale, who heads the Republican Party of India (A).

He cited the example of

Ajmer Sharif Dargah in Rajasthan, saying a large number of Hindus visit the shrine. "Our country is such that people of all religions should participate in each other's festivals. We oppose those taking such a stand. Such a stand is against the Constitution," he asserted.

The VHP last week announced that Muslims would not be allowed entry to 'garba' and 'dandiya' venues across Maharashtra during the Navratri festival, which begins on October 11.

circular economy and green mobility, including the possibility of connecting Indore's waste-management and Bio-CNG models with global technologies.

A UAE investment delegation is expected to visit Madhya Pradesh to explore opportunities in hotels, hospitality and tourism. Discussions also covered stronger air connectivity between Madhya Pradesh and the UAE, with potential benefits for tourism, cargo movement and business travel.

Tatarstan and Madhya Pradesh explored cooperation in advanced manufacturing, petrochemicals, food processing, engineering, logistics, agriculture and technology. Ethiopia and Ras Al Khaimah were also engaged on opportunities spanning agriculture, pharmaceuticals, manufacturing, logistics, renewable energy, tourism and medical devices.



Education for international K-12 schools and skill centres, while Choithrams showed interest in supermarkets, modern retail, food processing, packaging and direct procurement from local farmers. Rana Holdings held discussions on smart manufacturing, data centres, green hydrogen, green energy, e-mobility and agricultural machinery.

The World Bank expressed interest in financial and technical cooperation in AI and digital governance projects. BEEAH discussed cooperation in solid waste management, waste-to-energy, the

MPSC aspirant ends life in Pune on debt burden

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Pune

A 28-year-old man preparing for the Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) examinations allegedly died by suicide in Pune, with a debt of around ₹2.5 lakh suspected to be the reason, an official said on Wednesday.

The deceased, identified as Prathamesh Deshmukh, was a native of Paranda and was staying in a rented house in Navi Peth while preparing for MPSC exams, Deputy Commissioner of Police Krushikesh Rawale said. He was found hanging inside a room in his house in the morning, following which some residents alerted the police, he said.

Deshmukh left behind a two-page note containing details of 18-19 persons from whom he had borrowed money and the amounts he had repaid, Rawale said.

Police were questioning his family members to ascertain why he had borrowed the



money and were investigating the matter, he said. The exact time of the suicide will be known after the post-mortem report is received, DCP said.

Notably, the Mumbai Crime Branch is investigating a question paper leak involving the MPSC Drug Inspector (Group-B) screening examination held in March. MPSC aspirants recently staged protests in parts of the State, including Pune, demanding transparency in the recruitment process and action against the alleged paper leaks and irregularities in various examinations. The State Government has separately formed a high-level committee to suggest necessary improvements in the overall examination process, an official earlier said.

No SIR notice issued to Prof CNR Rao, clarifies GBA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

GBA Chief Commissioner M Maheshwar Rao on Wednesday said that no notice was issued to Bharat Ratna awardee Prof CNR Rao in connection with the ongoing SIR of the electoral roll, as appeared in a section of the media.

In a statement, the Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA) said there was a discrepancy in the name of Rao, but instead of issuing any notice, the Booth Level Officer recommended including his name. "No notice has been issued to the Hon'ble Bharat Ratna (awardee) Prof C N (R) Rao in connection with the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls in the Malleshwaram Assembly Constituency," the GBA said, quoting Maheshwar Rao, who is also the District Election Officer of Bengaluru Urban. The GBA said that, as part of the SIR, Enumeration Forms were respectfully delivered in person to Rao and his family members at their residence by the State SVEEP Nodal Officer, along with the Commissioner of the Bengaluru West City Corporation. The required information was also duly filled in. The GBA said Rao was enrolled as a voter in Part No-129, Serial No-431 of the 76-Malleshwaram Assembly Constituency in the electoral roll of 2002.

"At that time, his name was recorded as



Bharat Ratna awardee Prof CNR Rao

'Rama'. At present, he is registered as a voter in Part No-59, Serial No-187 of the 157-Malleshwaram Assembly Constituency, under the name 'Prof CN Rao M'. Accordingly, his name has also been included in the draft electoral roll," the statement said.

"A discrepancy was noticed in the name of the Hon'ble person in the electoral roll. In view of this, the Booth Level Officer (BLO), without issuing any notice, has recommended inclusion of his name in the final electoral roll, considering him to be a respected person. Accordingly, necessary action has been initiated to include his name in the final electoral roll," the GBA said. Prof Rao was not available for comments on the issue.



DRI nets 740 kg cannabis in eight pan-India raids, 13 held

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

In eight intelligence-driven operations carried out over the past two weeks, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has seized almost 740 kg of cannabis and charas, arresting 13 people under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985. According to the Finance Ministry on Wednesday, the amount seized includes 709.6 kg of ganja, 24.5 kg of high-grade hydroponic cannabis and 5 kg of charas.

The operations focused on consignments being transported by road, rail and air, highlighting the fact that traffickers still use several routes to move large quantities of narcotics.

The biggest seizure occurred on Tuesday when DRI officers, acting on certain inputs, stopped two trucks coming from Visakhapatnam on the Old Dhamtari Road near Raipur. When they searched the loading areas, they found 61 packets concealed within 10 sacks; field tests proved that the contents were cannabis. The officers seized 375.95 kg of the drug together with both vehicles

and arrested four people.

The Raipur route had already been the subject of a previous operation. On August 26, DRI teams halted a further truck close to the city and obtained approximately 124 kg of cannabis that had been hidden. Police arrested one person and seized the vehicle. Resistance was shown during a third highway raid. From September 5 to 6, officers pursued and stopped a truck on the Aurangabad-Patna Highway outside Patna. The people in the truck attacked the team, wounding one officer, while the driver



escaped. During the search, officers found a hidden com-

partment containing 90 packets of ganja weighing

140.5 kg. The truck was seized. Railways were also used. On September 3, DRI officers stopped three passengers in the general compartment of the Amarnath Express at Gorakhpur railway station. During a personal search, they found about 5 kg of charas hidden in knee-cap-shaped coverings wrapped around the thighs of two passengers and placed inside their sarees. Investigators said the consignment had been smuggled from Nepal.

The high-quality cargo was transported via international air routes. In three separate

missions over the past 15 days, DRI units stopped three passengers who had arrived from Hanoi and Bangkok at Hyderabad and Bengaluru airports. Together, they had approximately 24.6 kg of high-grade hydroponic cannabis.

These eight operations show the range of methods being used to conceal the drugs: using sacks stacked in the truck cargo areas, employing specially constructed cavities, hiding the drugs on trains by means of body concealment, and carrying them in passenger luggage on international

flights. Since commercial quantities of the drug carry severe penalties under the NDPS Act, further investigations into the suppliers, financiers, and intended destinations are ongoing.

The officials said the results achieved over the fortnight are evidence of a continuous and intelligence-based operation aimed at combating organised cannabis trafficking networks that operate across state and international borders. The drugs seized, the vehicles, and the people arrested have all been handled in accordance with the NDPS Act, 1985.

Looks like PM Modi wants entire Caste census process to fail, claims Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Wednesday alleged that the Government's decision to use open-ended questions instead of a drop-down list in the current format of the caste census is a "very serious flaw", and said it seems that Prime Minister Narendra Modi wants the entire process to "fail".

Congress general secretary in-charge communications [Jairam Ramesh said his party has held 17 press conferences across the country in the last four days and reiterated the demand for conducting the caste census in the right manner.

"A caste census is not just about counting castes, but about ensuring social justice. Right kind of questions -> Right data -> Right share -> Social justice," Ramesh said in a post in Hindi on X. Despite



Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh

repeated demands by the Congress, the Modi Government's decision to use open-ended questions of a drop-down list in the current format of the caste census is a "very serious flaw", he said.

"It seems Prime Minister (Narendra) Modi wants different names, sub-castes and spellings for the same caste to be recorded in the census, so

that the entire caste census process fails," Ramesh said.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi jointly wrote a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on this issue, along with the party's key demand to conduct the caste census in the right manner, but no

response has come yet.

Both senior leaders had expressed serious objections to the current process of the caste census in the letter dated August 20, he said.

The letter had demanded that the current questionnaire be scrapped and a new one be prepared based on a certified list of castes, Ramesh said. Conducting the count based on a pre-prepared and certified caste list, like the caste surveys in Telangana and Bihar, is a practical solution for this, he said.

The letter also demanded extensive consultation with political parties, experts and the public for the new questionnaire.

"The Congress has reiterated the demand for a caste census along with the above demands by holding 17 press conferences across the country in the last four days on this issue," Ramesh said.

Justice Bhati sworn in as J&K and Ladakh HC Chief Justice



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Justice Pushpendra Singh Bhati was sworn in as the Chief Justice of the High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh in Srinagar on Wednesday.

Justice Bhati was administered the oath of office by the Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena. Saxena is currently holding additional charge as LG of Jammu and Kashmir as incumbent Manoj Sinha is on leave.

Chief Minister Omar

Abdullah, judges of the High Court and subordinate courts were present at the oath-taking ceremony.

The Centre notified the appointment of Justice Bhati as Chief Justice of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court on September 5.

Justice Bhati took over from Justice Sanjeev Kumar, who was officiating as the acting chief justice.

The Supreme Court collegium had recommended Justice Bhati as the chief justice. He was earlier serving as a judge of the Rajasthan High Court.

Breakaway TMC offers Nandigram to Mamata

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

In what is seen as a 'clever and subtle' release of its cards — pushing Mamata Banerjee further to the brink — the breakaway faction of the Trinamool Congress led by Opposition Leader Ritabrata Banerjee on Wednesday said that his faction would not field any candidate in Nandigram Assembly by-elections should the former Chief Minister contest the polls from the high-profile seat.

Nandigram seat fell vacant after it was vacated by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, who happens to be the son of the soil. In the April-May State elections, Adhikari won both from Nandigram and Bhawanipore, defeating Mamata Banerjee at her home turf in Kolkata. Adhikari had already announced



earlier that his party would win the seat by a record margin in the by-elections. "I will personally campaign here and see that the seat is won by a record margin," he said, apparently making it difficult for anyone — even Mamata Banerjee to win it.

"We have no problem if Mamata Banerjee fights from Nandigram... We have been her soldiers, and we still have respect for her... We will leave the seat if she contests from Nandigram," former minister and breakaway TMC MLA Madan Mitra said. There was no immediate comment on the issue from the Mamata Banerjee faction which,

however, remained concerned with the appropriation of the party symbol. "The party symbol is the main issue now, and they are in a tight spot... We are sure to get it back," Kunal Ghosh, a Mamata loyalist, earlier said.

Another senior TMC leader and a former Minister said about Wednesday's development that "The card has been played very cleverly by the Ritabrata faction — which is presently under the full control of the BJP Government — so as to further humiliate and decimate Mamata Banerjee because it will be next to impossible for her to defeat BJP in Nandigram," which is Adhikari's home turf. Even in the 2021 Assembly elections, when TMC roared back to power with a thumping majority, Adhikari had defeated Banerjee by a margin of 1900 votes.

Political feuds must not diminish House, says Telangana Dy CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka has sought to shift the focus of a growing political controversy from the Congress-BRS confrontation to a larger question: the dignity and institutional authority of the Telangana Legislative Assembly.

Bhatti's public show of solidarity with Assembly Speaker Gaddam Prasad Kumar, alongside Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy, followed controversial remarks allegedly made by BRS leaders during protests around the Assembly. Congress leaders condemned the alleged comments, while the BRS disputed the Government's version of events and accused the ruling party of targeting the opposition.

The subsequent police action against BRS leaders



Telangana Dy CM Mallu Bhatti

has further intensified the political dispute. Amid the familiar cycle of accusations and counter-accusations, Bhatti has sought to place the Speaker's office at the centre of the debate. His message is that while an opposition has every right to challenge the Government, political rivalry should not cross the line into conduct that diminishes legislative institutions. The argument carries significance beyond party politics. The Assembly is the forum where Governments are held accountable, legislation is debated, and the mandate of voters is translated into policy.

Amravati NICU fire: Govt orders suspension of 5

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amravati

Over two weeks after three newborn babies died in a fire at the Amravati District Women's Hospital, the Maharashtra Government on Wednesday ordered the suspension of four officials and a technician, with a high-level probe committee holding them responsible for negligence and lapses. It also directed blacklisting of two private companies in connection with the incident.

The inquiry committee found that ventilators at the hospital were not maintained and repaired as required, fire alarm and sprinkler systems were not operational, the fire pump house was padlocked, and there were major faults in equipment maintenance. 3 newborn babies died and 36 others were rescued after a fire broke out in District Women's Hospital on August 24.

Kashmiri Pandit employees threaten strike over secure transit housing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

A large number of Kashmiri Pandit employees appointed under the Prime Minister's Package assembled at Press Colony in Srinagar on Wednesday, demanding an immediate end to the long delay in providing secure transit accommodation in the Valley. They have set September 30 as their deadline and warned that they will begin an indefinite protest and hunger strike from October 1 if the demand is not met.

The demonstration came amid fresh threat letters targeting employees recruited under the rehabilitation and employment package.

Several Kashmiri Pandit employees, gathered in the Press Colony, said many of them have been serving in Kashmir for years while still living in rented rooms because completed transit flats have not been handed over in time.

Their principal demand was immediate relocation to secured camps, particularly completed blocks at Zewan



in Srinagar, and faster occupation of other ready buildings across transit sites.

Speaking to the media in Srinagar, one Kashmiri Pandit employee, Ashish Razdan, said the community had been given a succession of official deadlines that had slipped. "Our major demand is something we have been raising with the Government for years. We have been here since 2010; it has been 16 years, and we still have not been provided safe accommodation. We have been given deadline after deadline: first April, then May,

June, July, August, and now the administration has given us September-end as the deadline. September 30 is our deadline. If our demand is not addressed by then, from October 1 onwards, we will be forced to go on strike, including a hunger strike," he said. He added that each new threat letter renewed families' fear.

Some of the employees claimed 29 of 36 buildings planned across seven transit camps in Srinagar had been completed and should be opened at once, while work on the remaining structures

should be stepped up.

Against a sanctioned target of 6,000 transit flats, 4,648 had been completed and 1,352 were still under construction as of May 31, 2026; 3,257 had been allotted, but only 881 were occupied. Zewan, the largest Srinagar site, has been a particular flashpoint: hundreds of flats have been allotted on paper while occupation has lagged.

Worried for their safety, these Kashmiri Pandit employees claimed they have been feeling unsafe ever since fresh threat letters have started surfacing on social media platforms.

The threat letters have warned Kashmiri Pandit PM Package employees to quit their jobs or face death, and some have carried names, addresses, phone numbers and vehicle details. Forums representing the employees have written to Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo seeking a security audit of workplaces, transit colonies and rented housing, protection for those named in the threats, an FIR and investigation into the leak of personal data.

Ladakh tourist footfall surpasses 2025 total in 8 months

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Ladakh is witnessing a sharp surge in tourist footfall this year. Between January 1 and August 31, 2026, 4,05,085 tourists visited the Union Territory, already higher than the 3,35,872 visitors recorded during the entire calendar year of 2025.

In eight months, arrivals have exceeded last year's full-year total by 20.61 per cent, with four months of the travel season still left.

The rise has been recorded in both domestic and foreign segments. During the first eight months of 2026, Ladakh received 3,71,739 domestic tourists and 33,346 foreign tourists. In the corresponding period of 2025, the figures were 2,44,308 domestic and 25,082 foreign visitors.

Compared with January-August 2025, when 2,69,390 tourists arrived, the 2026 eight-month total of 4,05,085 marks an increase of 50.37 per cent.

August was one of the strongest months of the year so far. Tourist arrivals rose from 45,201 in August 2025 to 74,753 in August 2026, a jump of 65.38 per cent. The month also recorded the highest foreign tourist footfall of 2026 so far, with 10,075 international visitors, against 8,148 in August 2025.

Lieutenant Governor, Vinai Kumar Saxena, attributed this significant tourism growth to the Centre's sustained push for infrastructure development in Ladakh as well as the appeal of the Prime Minister Narendra Modi to



citizens to visit tourist places in India and promote domestic tourism.

"The fact that Ladakh has already crossed its entire 2025 tourist footfall, in just eight months of this year, is a very encouraging sign. Our focus, however, is not merely on increasing tourist numbers, but on building a sustainable, responsible and year-round tourism economy that benefits our people. Festivals, sporting events and cultural programmes are helping us expand the tourism calendar beyond the traditional summer season and bringing visitors to Ladakh during the shoulder and off-seasons. This creates more sustained livelihood opportunities for our youth, entrepreneurs, homestays, artisans, transporters and local communities. At the same time, visitors will also have the advantage in terms of cheaper air fares, hotels and less crowd," said LG Saxena.

The sustained growth in tourist arrivals is also being supported by the Administration's efforts to promote events and festivals as instruments of tourism development, particularly beyond the traditional peak summer season. By developing a calendar of festivals, sporting events, cultural programmes, adventure activities and other experiences, the aim is to encourage visitors to travel to Ladakh during the shoulder and off-seasons as well.

In the month of August, major festivals like the Changthang Nomadic Festival, the first-ever Black-necked Crane Festival, the Suru Summer Festival and the Ladakh Book Festival added new attractions to Ladakh's tourism calendar, and attracted a large number of tourists.

The first edition of the Black-Necked Crane Festival alone saw the participation of more than 10,000 people from India and abroad. These festivals showcase the Ladakh region's unique culture, nomadic traditions, wildlife, and natural heritage. Ladakh's vibrant tourism calendar remains active in September as well, with a series of major events lined up, including Ladakh Bike Week, Ladakh Festival, Zanskar Festival, and the Ladakh Marathon. The marathon, in particular, attracts runners from across the country and beyond, with many participants travelling to Ladakh with their families, thereby generating wider benefits for hotels, homestays, restaurants, transport operators, guides, local businesses and other tourism-related services.

Editor's

TAKE

BRICS: India to balance Global South and West

The BRICS summit at Delhi offers India a chance to project itself as the Global South's convener without becoming an anti-Western camp

When Narendra Modi welcomes Vladimir Putin, Cyril Ramaphosa, and counterparts from an eleven-nation bloc to New Delhi on September 12-13, it will mark India's first BRICS chairmanship – its most consequential hosting since the 2023 G20 presidency. The theme – “Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability” – is compelling; the agenda is not: reformed multilateralism at the UN and IMF, balanced trade and smooth services flows within the bloc, supply chains for semiconductors and critical minerals, a Startup Innovation Fund, an AI governance framework, and an Agricultural Trade Conduct Protocol aimed at food security.

For India, the summit matters less for any single deliverable than for positioning. Hosting a bloc representing roughly 40 per cent of global GDP and nearly half of humanity lets New Delhi frame itself as the Global South's pragmatic convener – present at the table with Beijing and Moscow, but unwilling to be cast as anti-Western.

The guest list underlines this: India has invited the sitting chairs of the African Union, ASEAN, CELAC, and the Gulf Cooperation Council as observers, plus UN Secretary-General António Guterres as an expected special guest – a roster built to say New Delhi speaks for the wider developing world, not just for BRICS.

That distinction matters more this year, as Washington's tariff pressure over India's Russian oil purchases pushes New Delhi to hedge harder towards Moscow and Beijing while still resisting a bloc-wide anti-dollar posture.

The talking points to watch: India will push local-currency settlement and payment-system interoperability, while rejecting a common BRICS currency that would invite further American retaliation. Counter-terrorism and terror financing will get prominent language, a long-standing Indian priority. And the India-China thaw – seeded at the 2024 Kazan summit – will be visible.

The complication is that BRICS is not an instrument India fully controls. Iran and Russia want sharper anti-Western language than New Delhi is comfortable issuing as chair; the West Asia conflict had already sunk consensus at May's foreign ministers' meeting; and Saudi Arabia's ambivalent participation, alongside Argentina's withdrawal, shows this is a looser coalition than the G20 India ran in 2023. Critics have called the presidency a “crown of thorns” – diplomatic exposure for uncertain reward.

The likely outcome is not a triumphant joint declaration but a carefully hedged chair's statement: sharp language on trade facilitation, food security, and institutional reform; softer, vaguer language on Gaza and Ukraine; and modest, concrete wins such as the innovation fund and a digital-payments push.

That is India doing what it does best at these forums – converting it into proof of its own indispensability, without surrendering strategic autonomy.



Prime Minister Modi: Must he recalibrate?

Prime Minister Narendra Modi remains the BJP's central electoral asset, but signs of voter unease over the economy, jobs and governance are sharpening the need for political recalibration. With crucial state polls ahead and 2029 on the horizon, Modi faces the challenge of renewing his appeal without diminishing the strong leadership image that has defined his tenure



KALYANI SHANKAR

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi is reportedly working to improve his public image amid a complex array of domestic and international challenges. As a leader in a diverse, populous nation like India, Modi recognises the importance of maintaining strong public support. His commitment to listening to the people he serves is crucial for fostering trust and ensuring effective governance.

Recent data from India Today and the CVoter Mood of the Nation survey show Modi's popularity has declined to 49 per cent. In comparison, opposition leader Rahul Gandhi's appeal remains steady at 27 per cent. In electoral projections, the BJP is expected to lose 24 Lok Sabha seats, while Congress gains 26, suggesting economic issues are at the forefront of voters' concerns. The fact is, no other leader can replace him.

Modi is in his third term, and rebranding his public persona is crucial to addressing voter concerns. Emphasising economic recovery and job creation can help restore trust in his leadership.

Since taking office in 2014, Modi has faced numerous challenges that have shaped public perception of his leadership and trust in it. While his personal popularity has largely remained intact over the years, he experienced a setback in 2024 when he fell short of a majority in the elections.

For the 2029 election, he would lead his party for the fourth time. Still, his leadership is under scrutiny, particularly amid significant hurdles such as economic slowdowns, rising unemployment, and the devastating impact of the COVID-19 pandemic. These events have sparked criticism from opposition parties, economic experts and the wider public, fuelling discontent among citizens who lost jobs and saw businesses close during pandemic lockdowns.

Recently, the emergence of the CJP has surprised him and his government.

Booker Prize author Arundhati Roy has observed, “PM Modi's image, built over 24 years at the cost of crores, destroyed in two weeks by CJP.”

One of Modi's key objectives is to enhance his image on the global stage, especially as India gains prominence in international affairs. Beyond domestic issues, Modi must also navigate the international arena effectively. As India continues to rise on the global stage, how he is perceived internationally will have significant implications for diplomatic relations and



THE UPCOMING BRICS SUMMIT OFFERS MODI A UNIQUE OPPORTUNITY TO IMPROVE BOTH INDIA'S AND HIS OWN INTERNATIONAL IMAGE. SIGNIFICANT EFFORTS ARE UNDERWAY TO ENSURE THE SUMMIT'S SUCCESS, REFLECTING INDIA'S GROWING INFLUENCE AND ECONOMIC POTENTIAL

The writer is a popular columnist

foreign investment. By working to rebuild his and India's image, Modi can emphasise a leadership style that is both sophisticated and approachable, enhancing India's standing as an influential player in global politics. Engaging with international partners and addressing pressing global challenges could help solidify his reputation as a capable leader on multiple fronts.

The upcoming BRICS summit offers Modi a unique opportunity to improve both India's and his own international image. Significant efforts are underway to ensure the summit's success, reflecting India's growing influence and economic potential.

The current economic distress has led to Modi pursuing initiatives to spur economic recovery and restore public confidence. By demonstrating his commitment to confronting these challenges head-on, Modi aims to reassure voters that he is prepared to take decisive action to resolve issues affecting the nation's future.

Modi's leadership style is characterised by strong nationalism and decisiveness, which has earned him a loyal base of supporters. However, to broaden his appeal, he may need to present a more inclusive image that emphasises unity and diversity.

Because state elections are driven by political planning and strategy, these factors matter more. Modi is likely to highlight his government's achievements in infrastructure development, digital transformation, welfare programmes, and improvements in health-care and education. Showcasing these successes can help demonstrate his effectiveness as a leader and bolster his public image.

To achieve these goals, Modi likely uses a range of communication strategies, includ-

ing social media, public speeches, and direct engagement with local issues. His oratory and direct approach to the public have yielded results. His messaging often emphasises empathy, responsiveness, and accountability-qualities that resonate deeply with voters, particularly during challenging times.

In conclusion, Modi's efforts to rebuild his public image reflect a multifaceted strategy to address internal challenges and external perceptions. By skilfully navigating public sentiment, economic realities, and global dynamics, he seeks to strengthen his leadership and advance his agenda. This comprehensive approach is essential for any leader who aims to stay relevant and maintain support in an ever-evolving political landscape, especially as he prepares for future electoral challenges.

And above all, no other leader is in sight who can go beyond his popularity.

Modi's efforts to rebuild his image reflect a multifaceted strategy to address both internal challenges and external perceptions. By skilfully navigating public sentiment, he aims to strengthen his leadership and advance his agenda. This strategic approach is essential for any leader who seeks to maintain relevance and support in an ever-changing political landscape.

In next year's election in Uttar Pradesh (UP), the BJP must aim to retain control of the state. Winning elections in other states is also important. The BJP's election machinery operates continuously. Modi should ensure that the public perceives him as a strong leader.

The upcoming state elections will present a significant challenge for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The forthcoming year is poised to be difficult for both Prime Minister Modi and the BJP.

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The Self That Watches Itself

We live so entangled with our thoughts, our worries, our achievements, and our failures, that we often forget there is a difference between the mind and the one observing it. The Mundaka Upanishad captures this through a striking image of two birds seated on the very same tree.

One bird hops from branch to branch, eating the fruits of the tree, tasting both their sweetness and their bitterness. When the fruit is sweet, it is thrilled; when bitter, it recoils in distress. It is restless, constantly reaching for the next fruit, convinced that satisfaction lies just one branch away. The other bird does something entirely different. It does not eat. It simply watches, calm and luminous, untouched by whether the fruit its companion tastes is sweet or sour. It is not indifferent to life, only unshaken by it.

The eating bird represents the individual self, the ego, the part of us swept along by every gain and loss, every praise and criticism, every joy and sorrow. The watching bird represents the true Self, the silent witness that observes the mind's endless activity without being disturbed by it.

The Upanishad tells us that true freedom comes when the eating bird finally turns and sees the still bird beside it, and realizes they were never two separate beings at all. Most of us live entirely as the first bird, hopping restlessly from one experience to the next, mistaking every reaction for who we are. Today, when a strong emotion arises, pause for a moment and try to observe it from a slight distance, as the watching bird would, rather than being fully consumed by it.



RAJYOGI BRAHMA KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

For generations, Ganesh Chaturthi has been celebrated with grandeur and devotion all over the world. Families install idols, offer prayers, distribute sweets, and finally immerse Ganpati ji's idol in rivers or seas with a heart-felt farewell. Over the decades, this festival has also grown into something bigger than a household ritual: a public spectacle of towering pandals, competing sound systems, and processions that stretch for days. Yet, over the years, it has also left behind something unintended: polluted waters, toxic chemicals, and mounds of plastic waste. All of this raises an important question: What does it really mean to worship Lord Ganesha?

True celebration goes beyond idols and decorations. Lord Ganpati's form is itself a lesson in harmony, balance, and respect for nature. His large stomach



teaches us to “digest” the ups and downs of life without losing balance. His rat reminds us not to let small, destructive habits ruin our lives. His swastika symbolises the eternal cycle of renewal. Together, they point to an eco-spiritual message of living in balance with the world around us. Even the modak he is offered, wrapped in a simple leaf and made of rice, was once a lesson in using what nature freely gives and not what a factory manufactures.

Today, when climate change threatens our very survival, Ganesh Chaturthi gives us a chance to rethink what devotion really means. Can devotion be measured only by the size of idols or the loudness of celebrations? Or is it reflected in the purity of our actions, the way we care for the Earth, water, and air that sustain us? Across India, young people are already leading this change. From using

clay idols and natural colours, eco-friendly Ganesh celebrations are slowly becoming a new tradition. Many suburbs in Mumbai and Pune now organise community immersions in artificial ponds and tanks, proving that scale and sustainability do not have to be enemies. This is not just about saving the environment; it is about aligning the festival with the very values Lord Ganesha represents: wisdom, responsibility, and foresight.

The elephant-headed deity is known as Vighnaharta, the remover of obstacles. Today, one of the greatest obstacles humanity faces is the damage we have done to our planet. So, if we truly wish to honour Lord Ganesha, we must begin by removing this obstacle through conscious choices: reducing waste, recycling, respecting natural resources, and promoting sustainable lifestyles. Remember! In truth, worship is not about what we offer in rituals, but what we practise in life. An idol made of clay may dissolve in a few hours, but the values we absorb from Lord Ganesha can last a lifetime. Hence, being eco-friendly is not a compromise; it is the most authentic way to live the spirit of Ganesh Chaturthi. As we welcome Ganpati ji this year, let us carry home not just an idol, but also an intention: the intention to live with balance, to protect nature, and to pass on a cleaner, healthier planet to future generations. That is the truest offering we can make at the feet of Lord Ganesha.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and columnist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Time for accountability, not promises

The Satya Niketan hostel collapse was not merely an accident; it was the predictable result of a system that repeatedly ignores safety until tragedy strikes. A 50-year-old building, illegally converted, with load-bearing walls removed and a waterlogged basement, should never have been allowed to house students. Yet it did because inspections exist largely on paper and enforcement remains weak.

Arresting the landlord and suspending five officials is not enough. What is needed is independent inspections, public registries of certified buildings and genuine accountability for every official who failed to act. This is not just a Delhi problem. Across India, millions of students live in illegally converted hostels that may be unsafe and unchecked. The pattern is painfully familiar: neglect, tragedy, condolences and then silence until the next collapse.

Structural audits and safety certificates are useful only when they are enforced honestly. Parents who send their children to study in cities deserve to know that the buildings they live in are safe. Anything less amounts to criminal negligence.

The time for promises is over. The time for action is now.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BENGALURU

New arsenal in Indian armoury

The reported decision by India to acquire the sophisticated and battle-tested javelin anti-tank guided missile (ATGM) system from the United States is significant. The javelin is a versatile and highly portable weapon system with advanced capabilities against armoured targets. Its induction would strengthen India's battlefield capabilities. However, the proposed arrangement raises an important question about India's quest for Atmanirbharta in defence. While the Javelin All-Up Rounds (AURs) are reportedly to be produced in India through a joint venture involving the Javelin Joint Venture (JJV) and Tata Advanced Systems Ltd (TASL), several critical components are expected to continue to be manufactured in the US.

This means India could remain dependent on the US for vital technologies and components. Such dependence could become a constraint during geopolitical tensions or disruptions in global supply chains.

A more beneficial agreement would include comprehensive technology transfer, enabling India to manufacture the complete system domestically. Merely assembling imported components cannot be equated with genuine technological self-reliance. The javelin may strengthen India's armoury today, but true strategic strength will come when India can develop such weapons independently.

THARCIUS S FERNANDO | CHENNAI

UPI charges could undermine trust

Amid the outcry against charging fees for UPI transactions, the Prime Minister has voiced support for expanding its operational base. The law passed by Parliament removes the legal barrier to charging Merchant Discount Rate (MDR). However, it does not itself notify the rate or begin collection.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, replying in the Rajya Sabha on August 11 when the Bill was returned, said: “The enabling provision that we are bringing in today does not impose any tax or transaction charge on UPI users.” She also said consumers and small merchants would not have to pay MDR charges on UPI transactions and that the MDR framework was yet to be finalised. Government sources quoted in media reports said the intent was to allow a small charge only for large merchants with turnover of more than ₹1-1.5 crore and for transactions above ₹2,000, limiting it to about 5 per cent of all UPI transactions.

The burden could ultimately be shifted to customers, creating a trust deficit. UPI's phenomenal growth was driven by its being free, and any charge could slow its adoption. With PhonePe and Google Pay dominating the market, concerns over costs and foreign ownership add to the apprehension.

AG RAJMOHAN | ANDHRA PRADESH



People perform 'aarti' during the arrival ceremony of Khanbhaag Cha Maharaja for the 'Ganesh Chaturthi' festival, at Sangli, Maharashtra PHOTO: PTI

PICTALK

UN votes to redraw the world: Global South to get its true size

The UN’s overwhelming backing for a more accurate map of the world may look like a cartographic correction. But behind the push to reduce Mercator’s dominance lies a larger Global South challenge to inherited ways of representing geography, power and place



SANTHOSH MATHEW

“A map is not just a picture of the world; it is a picture of how we understand the world.” That idea has acquired a new significance at the United Nations, where the General Assembly has overwhelmingly backed a resolution calling for a more accurate representation

of the size of the world’s continents. In a remarkable vote, 164 countries supported the resolution, the United States voted against it and six countries abstained. Led by Togo, with the backing of the African Union, the initiative seeks to correct the distortions created by the world map that generations have grown up with. Africa is set to appear much closer to its actual size, while Europe and North America will lose some of the visual prominence they acquire on the familiar Mercator projection. What appears at first to be a technical debate among cartographers has therefore become something much bigger: a statement from the Global South that the map of the world should reflect the world as it actually exists.

The resolution promotes the wider use of equal-area map projections, including the Equal Earth projection, developed in 2018. The purpose is not to declare one map the only correct map, nor does the resolution ban the centuries-old Mercator projection. It encourages the use of projections that preserve the relative area of continents when the purpose is to understand their actual geographical size. That distinction matters because every flat map of a spherical Earth involves some distortion. The real question is what a map chooses to preserve and what it chooses to distort. The Mercator projection preserves angles and directions, which made it exceptionally useful for navigation. Equal-area projections give priority to preserving the relative size of landmasses. In an age of satellites, GPS and digital cartography, the world no longer needs to depend on one projection for every purpose.

The Mercator map has a remarkable history. Flemish cartographer Gerardus Mercator introduced it in 1569, when European ships were venturing across oceans in search of new trade routes and territories. His objective was not to create a map that accurately compared the size of continents. It was to help sailors navigate. By preserving angles and directions, Mercator produced a revolutionary tool for maritime navigation. The map served its original purpose brilliantly. The difficulty came when a map created for sailors gradually became the most familiar visual representation of the entire planet. A navigation chart was transformed into a picture through which generations of schoolchildren came to understand the world. The distortion becomes obvious when we compare Greenland with Africa. On a conventional Mercator map, Greenland can appear almost as large as Africa. In reality, Africa is roughly 14 times larger than Greenland. The reason is mathematical. As the spherical Earth is projected onto a flat surface, areas become increasingly enlarged towards the poles. Greenland, located close to the Arctic, is therefore dramatically exaggerated, while Africa, much closer to the Equator, appears considerably smaller than its actual area. Europe and North America also acquire a greater visual size, while Africa and South America are compressed. The map is not “wrong” in the sense that Mercator failed at his original task. It becomes misleading when people use it to compare the actual geographical size of continents.

This is where the new UN initiative acquires its political and cultural significance. For the Global South, the problem is not merely that Africa looks smaller on a classroom map. Maps influence the imagination. Children encounter the world first through maps before they learn about population, resources, economic power or political influence. What appears large can unconsciously appear important; what appears small can seem peripheral. A cartographic distortion can therefore become a distortion of perception. The African argument is that a continent whose geographical reality is immense should not continue to be visually diminished simply because a sixteenth-century navigation system became the standard image of the world.

Togo’s initiative, supported by the African Union, reflects a broader effort to challenge inherited systems of representation. The resolution highlights the educational, cultural, political, social and economic consequences of distorted maps. The underlying argument is powerful: geographical representation is not politically neutral when the same visual distortion is repeated for generations.

The history of cartography demonstrates the relationship between maps and power. Empires mapped territories they controlled, colonial administrations mapped



“IF THE PICTURE OF THE WORLD IS DISTORTED, OUR UNDERSTANDING OF THE WORLD WILL BE DISTORTED TOO.” THAT IS THE LARGER MESSAGE BEHIND THIS SEEMINGLY UNUSUAL UN RESOLUTION. THE EARTH HAS NOT CHANGED SINCE MERCATOR DREW HIS MAP NEARLY FIVE CENTURIES AGO. OUR TECHNOLOGY HAS CHANGED, OUR GEOPOLITICS HAS CHANGED AND THE GLOBAL SOUTH’S VOICE HAS GROWN LOUDER

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borders and resources, and governments used maps to define political space. Yet the Mercator projection was created primarily for navigation, and its technical value remains undeniable. The important point is that the world has changed while the visual convention has remained remarkably persistent. The Equal Earth projection offers a different approach, preserving the relative areas of continents more accurately. Africa appears larger, South America gains its geographical weight and Asia’s enormous scale becomes more apparent. No flat map can eliminate distortion, but Equal Earth is better suited to comparing continental size.

India’s support for the resolution reflects this wider Global South context. New Delhi has backed greater cartographic accuracy while emphasising that different maps serve different purposes. The principle is not simply to replace Mercator with Equal Earth, but to use the projection most appropriate to the purpose.

The United States, the only country to vote against the resolution, criticised the initiative as unnecessary while the world faces wars, economic crises, climate change and migration. But if maps are among the first tools through which people learn about the world, representation matters. It shapes perception and how people understand their place in the world.

The UN resolution therefore should not be interpreted as the death of the Mercator projection. It is better understood as a challenge to its universal dominance. Mercator will remain useful for specific navigational purposes. The resolution asks governments, educational institutions and international organisations to give greater consideration to equal-area projections when geographical size is the subject being represented. That is a modest technical change on paper, but it carries a larger symbolic message. The world of the twenty-first century is no longer the world of sixteenth-century sailing ships. Satellites can photograph the Earth, computers can model it in three dimensions and digital platforms can switch between projections instantly. There is little reason to pretend that one centuries-old projection must serve every modern purpose.

The real significance of the vote lies in the fact that the Global South is increasingly questioning not only the distribution of economic and political power, but also the systems through which knowledge about the world has been produced and communicated. Africa is not becoming larger because of this resolution. Europe is not becoming smaller. The geographical facts have never changed. What is changing is the representation of those facts. The new map simply asks people to see Africa as large as Africa really is, South America as large as South America really is and Asia in proportion to its enormous geographical reality.

The debate also offers a lesson in humility. There is no perfect world map. Every projection involves choices. The important thing is to recognise those choices instead of treating a particular map as an unquestionable picture of reality. The Mercator projection was a masterpiece for navigation. Equal Earth is better suited to showing relative land area. Other projections will remain useful for climate studies, aviation, regional mapping and many other purposes. The future of cartography should therefore be plural rather than uniform, accurate rather than inherited. For the Global South, this is ultimately about more than cartography.

It is about visibility and correcting a visual imbalance repeated so often that it came to look natural. The UN vote gives that argument an international platform. A map cannot redistribute power, but it can change how people understand it. “If the picture of the world is distorted, our understanding of the world will be distorted too.” That is the larger message behind this seemingly unusual UN resolution. The Earth has not changed since Mercator drew his map nearly five centuries ago. Our technology has changed, our geopolitics has changed and the Global South’s voice has grown louder. Now the cartographic picture is being asked to catch up with reality. The world is not being redrawn; the way we see the world is.

Swami Vivekananda’s Vision of Oneness



ASHISH TRIPATHI

Bharat is a land of great saints and sages. It is the land where great souls, with the light of their wisdom, illuminated their surroundings and spread their teachings to the far corners of the world. This light of wisdom brought a qualitative change to the lives of billions of people.

A renowned name among these luminaries is Swami Vivekananda. He is the one who, through his deeds and ideas, renewed the ancient idea of ‘Vishwa Bandhutva’ across the globe and granted it a tangible shape.

Swami Ji drew the inspiration to lead this holy task from the profound teachings of his guru, Swami Ramakrishna Paramhansa, whose entire life was dedicated to the service of mankind. ‘Nar Seva-Narayan Seva’ was the supreme ideal of his life. This highest ideal was fully embraced and lived by his great disciple Vivekananda, who made it his life’s motto. The disciple invested all his spiritual power in realising his guru’s goal to its fullest potential.

Swami Vivekananda, along with other close disciples of his guru, founded the Ramakrishna Math on May 1, 1897 with the aim of propagating and materialising the teachings and vision of their master. This became a great centre of religious and spiritual activities, where people from diverse backgrounds could experience a spiritual atmosphere conducive to enlightenment. Simultaneously, Swami Vivekananda founded the Ramakrishna Mission. The Mission is dedicated to fulfilling *Samajik Sarokar* (social responsibility) and *Samajik Seva* (social service). It focuses on uplifting the quality of life for ordinary men and women by offering cultural, educational and medical assistance based on the foundational principles and highest ideals of Sanatan Dharma.

Swami Vivekananda possessed an unmatched personality. As a man of action, he led various outstanding initiatives throughout his life, but his rarest achievement was preaching Vedantic teachings to the entire world. He was the one who most judiciously propagated this ancient philosophy in the 19th century. His works were rooted in rationality and logic, and carried a deep touch of humanity. Vivekananda was a sincere and captivating figure; his vision and mission fascinated commoners whenever he visited public spaces. His electrifying ideas, passionate gestures, and charismatic aura exerted an immense influence on the masses. In 1893, he travelled to Chicago for the Parliament of the World’s Religions. On 11 September, he addressed this international conference, which delegates from various religious sects attended. Swami Ji was the representative of Bharat and Hindutva. He began his speech with the iconic words, “Sisters and Brothers of America...” He was not only deeply appreciated by the audience but also received a massive mark of respect. This not only established an affable relationship with his listeners but also set him apart from the crowd. The core philosophy behind these mesmerising words was inspired and driven by the Advaita Vedanta tradition of Indian philosophy. The Sanskrit term *Advaita* refers to the non-dualistic nature of reality. This term is extensively discussed in Hindu scriptures to explain the unity between *jiva* (the individual soul) and Brahman (the cosmic soul). This philosophy of *Advaita* teaches us the idea of oneness and the unity of the self. Popular philosophical texts like the Vivekachudamani and Brahmagyanaavali Mala beautifully define this notion:

“*Brahma Satyam Jagan-mithya Jivo-Brahmaiva naparah*” This means that Brahman alone is real, the world is illusory, and the individual soul (*jiva*) is none other than Brahman. The famous Upanishadic Mahavakya (grand pronouncement), “Aham Brahmasmi”, also refers to the unity of the individual self with Brahman, the Universal Absolute. Through these verses, it is entirely clear that the supreme entity exists commonly and universally in each and every creature of this universe. Therefore, we must think of unity, speak of unity, and act in unity. Swami Vivekananda delivered this great message of Vedantic Darshana to the world. Wherever he travelled as a Parivrajaka (wandering monk), he preached the idea of universal brotherhood, which lies at the core of Hindu Sanskriti (culture). The ancient shastras of Sanatan Dharma elaborate on this idea of oneness in every entity of the universe. The ancient Indian text Hitopadesha articulates this beautifully through the verse:

Ayam nijah paroveti ganana laghuchetasam Udaracharitanam tu vasudhaiva kutumbakam This literally means that only narrow-minded people perceive things through a discriminatory outlook, whereas broad-minded people view the entire world as one family. Swami Vivekananda was a man of broad vision who always cast aside the notions of duality and saw an instinctive uniformity in everyone. In his speeches and letters, he drew attention to the significance of Advaita Darshana, which highlights the uniqueness of oneness in every man, woman, and creature, beyond the barriers of caste, class, and creed. He emphasised universal brotherhood for the betterment of the world and its people. His memorable speech at the Parliament of the World’s Religions underlined incredible ideas such as brotherhood, tolerance, and acceptance. He received a standing ovation for his vision of religious harmony and the essence of humanity; consequently, his approach made a profound impact on the Western world.

Swami Vivekananda had a great vision for India; he viewed the society and surroundings of his nation with a practical attitude. He journeyed across India, covering different regions and sections of society, where he observed various problems in the lives of ordinary people. He identified poverty, starvation, illiteracy, and poor health conditions as the major challenges facing Indian society. As a true genius, he realised that one cannot accept or pursue a spiritual path under such miserable conditions. Therefore, with the motto “*Atmano mokshartham jagat hitaya cha*” (For one’s own liberation and for the welfare of the world), he stood up to transform the lives of India’s underprivileged sections. He led this venture under the umbrella of the Ramakrishna Mission, which even today works in education, healthcare, disaster relief, and other humanitarian activities across the country. The work of the Ramakrishna Mission inculcates the values of kindness and compassion within us and celebrates the Upanishadic assertion of “*Tena tyaktena bhunjitha*” (Find your enjoyment through renunciation).

Thus, these great ideals of service and sacrifice form the core of Bharatiya Chintan Parampara (Indian thought tradition), which continually illuminates the world with a ray of hope—a ray that is bringing a drastic change all around. May these eminent ideas of Swami Ji always give us the true strength to overcome the weaknesses within us, as he himself beautifully said: “Strength is life, weakness is death!”



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The GDP mirage: What India’s growth numbers don’t tell us



KAJLEEN KAUR

The Indian economy is both celebrating and debating between figures of 7.8 per cent and 2.6 per cent as the latest quarter’s GDP growth rate. The proponents of the promising number are explaining the statistical credibility of data-crunching techniques, with changes in methodology and the adoption of a new GDP series with 2022-23 as the base year. Not to forget, the IMF handed India a ‘C’ grade for its macroeconomic tracking metrics in late 2025 due to inconsistencies in base-year calculations. The focal point of the entire economic conversation gets reduced to whether one provisional and not even permanent number is right or wrong. Fascinating short-term figures are no testament to economic transformation.

India’s aspiration to become a developed economy by 2047 requires sustained high growth. Better economic performance is a package to be assessed in terms of not just the growth rate but also related macroeconomic parameters, including investment, manufactur-



ing, employment opportunities, currency value, and others, which, ironically, do not complement the high GDP numbers. India still suffers from a slow increase in private and foreign investment. The World Bank estimates that between 2012 and 2023, China accounted for nearly one-third of FDI flowing to developing economies, while Brazil received about 10 per cent and India about 6 per cent. India’s share in global exports has been stagnant for years, and the rupee witnessed its fastest devaluation in nearly a decade, losing 11 per cent in 2025-26. Assessing the employment situation in India, youth unemployment reached a 15-month high in June 2026, with urban youth unemployment at 18.2 per cent and young women at 20 per cent. In 2025, only 23.6 per cent of the workforce held a regular wage or salaried job, earning between ₹18,000 and ₹24,000 on average; 56.2 per cent were self-employed, and 20.2 per cent were casual labourers, earning between ₹315 per day for female workers and ₹455 for males. India has a large share of tiny firms managing with casual labour, paying below-median wages and

maintaining an unorganised structure of employment. A well-employed structure requires workers to move from low-productivity farms and household enterprises into industry and reach larger markets. If India is to convert its demographic advantage into a genuine demographic dividend, it needs investment that generates jobs and raises productivity. GDP can rise through several channels, but sustainable development requires a stronger investment-to-employment-to-income cycle.

An even more relevant issue is how effectively GDP numbers are converted into better lives. A country can record impressive economic growth while its citizens continue to struggle with deprivation. India needs to move beyond simple numbers to understand what it is delivering to its citizens. We struggle in terms of meeting global stan-

dards of basic amenities and social indicators, including education, healthcare, inequality and poverty. The Economic Survey 2025-26 and the latest NITI Aayog assessment recognise education and health, employment and skill development, rural development, investment and infrastructure as central components of India’s economic transformation.

The latest UNDP Human Development Report places India at 130th among 193 countries. Even today, only 63 per cent of the population is reported to have access to safely managed sanitation services. Urbanisation brings another challenge: cities are becoming engines of economic activity, but congestion, waste, pollution and inadequate public infrastructure can undermine the very productivity that urbanisation is expected to create. While investment in building new physical infrastructure is not lacking, maintenance is starkly overlooked, as it is politically less visible.

India’s development challenge becomes clearer when we look beyond GDP and the size of the economy and focus on how much better we are growing in terms of quality of life and sustainable numbers.

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Order Order

SC to begin final hearing on pleas concerning marital rape

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said it would list for final hearing after three weeks a batch of petitions pertaining to the contentious issue of marital rape. The apex court is seized of petitions raising the vexed legal question of whether a husband should enjoy immunity from prosecution for the offence of rape if he forces his wife, who is not a minor, to have sex.

Under the exception clause of Section 375 of the Indian Penal Code, now repealed and replaced by the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, sexual intercourse or sexual acts by a man with his wife, the wife not being minor, is not rape. Even under the new law, exception 2 to section 63 (rape) says that "sexual intercourse or sexual acts by a man with his own wife, the wife not being under eighteen years of age, is not rape". (PTI)



SC alleges Yatharth Hospital for not responding to contempt notice

The Supreme Court on Wednesday rapped Yatharth Super Speciality Hospital for not responding to a contempt notice issued by it over preparation of a standard operating procedure (SOP) for providing emergency medical care to EWS patients.



A bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Shree Chandrashekar sought reply from the hospital in two weeks. The top court noted that the hospital in its affidavit stated that it had not been served with any notice to participate.

"This statement is contrary to the office report dated April 2, 2026, which clearly records that notice had been served. The statement made in the reply is, therefore, ex facie false. Accordingly, we draw up formal contempt proceedings against the said respondent through its Medical Superintendent," the bench said.

During the hearing, the top court was informed by amicus curiae and senior advocate Sanjay Jain that only 12 hospitals have participated in the meeting out of 52.

He informed the apex court that a revised standard operating procedure (SOP) has been filed as per the court's direction. "It is stated that only 12 hospitals participated in the consultation process. Senior counsel appearing on behalf of several hospitals submit that they wish to file their responses and suggestions to the revised SOP," the bench said while posting matter for hearing on September 30. (PTI)

HC directs to Assam to pay two women for pushing them to Bangladesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

The Gauhati High Court has directed the Assam government to pay interim compensation of Rs 2 lakh each to the families of two women, who were declared non-citizens by a foreigners tribunal and pushed into Bangladesh without informing their kin or allowing them to exhaust their legal remedies.

Hearing two separate petitions, a division bench of Justices Kalyan Rai Surana and Susmita Phukan Khaund, in its September 3 orders, impleaded the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) as a respondent to facilitate the repatriation of Mumtaz Begum and Jahanara Begum.

Both women were declared non-citizens by a



foreigners tribunal in Nagaon's Juria. For Mumtaz Begum, the petition in the high court was filed by her husband Mujammel Hoque, while Jahanara Begum's son Mujahidul Islam filed the other plea.

Citing Supreme Court judgments, the high court said Article 21 of the Constitution guarantees protection of life and personal liberty not only to Indians, but also to non-citizens.

UP to challenge HC order quashing NSA on student

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta on Wednesday told the Supreme Court that an appeal would be filed against an Allahabad High Court decision quashing the detention of a Delhi University student and activist Akriti Chaudhary under the National Security Act (NSA).

The top law officer made the statement before a three-judge bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana.

SG Mehta referred to an earlier mentioning by a senior counsel in relation to a notice issued to a Greater Noida student over participa-



tion in the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led protest at Jantar Mantar, and clarified the notice was issued by an executive magistrate of Greater Noida and not the district magistrate.

"I am not on the matter.. (but) the Noida DM is flooded with queries from media, etc. what order have you

passed, etc," SG Mehta said.

As the bench recalled that the Allahabad High Court has recently quashed an order of the Gautam Buddha Nagar administration on the detention of another student and awarded compensation to her, SG Mehta said, "That we are challenging."

Earlier today, the CJ came

down heavily on the Greater Noida executive magistrate for issuing notice to a student for taking part in the CJP-led Jantar Mantar protest, asking how the magistrate "dared" to issue a notice despite the court's earlier order.

The apex court said it would seek explanation from the Greater Noida executive magistrate over the issue.

The Allahabad High Court on September 2 quashed the detention of Chaudhary under the NSA in relation to the April workers' protest in Noida.

A division bench of Justice Atul Sreedharan and Justice Achal Sachdev had strongly criticised the manner in which the detention order was passed by the Noida

district magistrate and warned that continued "despotic" conduct by "errant" bureaucracy could reduce Uttar Pradesh to an Orwellian Dystopia.

It also awarded Rs 5 lakh compensation to Chaudhary and directed that the amount be recovered from the salary of the Gautam Buddha Nagar DM Medha Roopam, who passed the detention order, as well as other officers responsible right down to the SHO.

Chaudhary is a history graduate from Delhi University and was arrested in connection with cases arising from the Noida workers' protest in April 2026. The UP Police subsequently invoked the NSA

against Chaudhary and activist-journalist Satya Verma on May 13. They were among several activists arrested in cases relating to the peaceful protest seeking higher wages.

In the order, the high court also made several significant observations on the roles of the bureaucracy and the police. It said officers are entrusted with immense powers because they bear responsibility for upholding the constitutional and legal rights, dignity, honour and welfare of citizens.

It directed that the high court's displeasure against the DM and police officers involved in preparing the dossier be recorded in their service records.

SC allows Himachal to withdraw cases against MLAs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday allowed the Himachal Pradesh government to withdraw prosecution against some sitting or former MLAs in several criminal cases registered during the COVID-19 pandemic period.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana noted that no grave or heinous crimes were alleged in these cases, which included those related to burning of effigies and 'dharnas' on highways.

The top court's order came while hearing a plea filed by the state government challenging a April 2024 order of



the Himachal Pradesh High Court. The high court had passed the order on an application filed by the state in 2023 seeking its permission to withdraw the prosecution in 65 cases against sitting or former MLAs on the basis of instructions issued by the home department in December 2022. The high court had partly allowed the state's plea and

permitted withdrawal of 15 cases. The state then moved the apex court challenging the high court order. On Wednesday, the counsel appearing for the state said they had sought the high court's permission to withdraw the prosecution in these cases. "There is nothing serious in these cases. There was no damage to public

property and there was no injury caused," the counsel said. The top court noted that in the application filed before the high court, 65 cases were mentioned, out of which five were disposed of while the matter was pending there.

It said the high court permitted withdrawal of 15 cases and out of the remaining 45 cases, four cases resulted in acquittal or discharge.

The bench observed that incidents alleged in these cases pertain to the period of the COVID-19 pandemic which was an exceptional situation where people, including public representatives, were in distress in different manners. It said none of these cases shows any grave or heinous crime.

SC asks CBSE to consider 3-language policy exemption for Class 6

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to consider exempting Class 6 students from its three-language policy for this academic year.

A three-judge bench led by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, while deferring the hearing on a batch of pleas challenging the CBSE's three-language policy to September 17, asked the Board to look into the possibility of accommodating the students of Class 6 in the ongoing academic session. "Consider Class 6 for this



year... If they can be given some accommodation," the bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, told Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta.

SG Mehta requested the court to defer the hearing on the pleas as Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati was not available.

He nonetheless assured that the officials concerned would consider the bench's suggestion. "All of us would sit together and revert to your lordship," the top law officer said. The senior counsel for one of the petitioners said the matter should not be delayed due to more adjournments as stu-

dents have to ultimately take an examination and it was causing anxiety among their parents. The apex court was hearing a batch of pleas challenging the CBSE's policy mandating the study of three languages, including two native Indian languages, for Class 9 students from July 1.

On August 20, the Supreme Court had stressed the need to find a solution to issues arising out of the CBSE policy mandating the study of three languages by Class 9 students, observing that children should not come under any kind of pressure.

It had said there was nothing wrong in introducing the policy but the only

concern raised by the petitioners was about the manner in which it was being introduced.

The bench had noted that one of the aspects that was required to be considered was how to build adequate human resource infrastructure with regard to the language options available.

"If you have chosen Class 6 as the starting point, you may consider giving a reprieve to Class 6 students of this year. You can introduce it from next year," it had said.

The senior counsel for one of the petitioners has contended that the CBSE has no jurisdiction or authority to frame the curriculum for

classes 6 to 8 as this has to be done by the NCERT.

On May 27, the top court had agreed to examine a plea challenging the policy and issued notices to the Centre, the CBSE and the NCERT seeking their responses. According to a circular issued by the CBSE, the study of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, has been made compulsory for Class 9 students beginning July 1.

The move is part of the CBSE's alignment of its scheme of studies with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE), 2023.

SC questions BCCI, state bodies' exemption from sports governance act

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

The Supreme Court has asked the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) and all the state cricket associations why they should not be governed by the National Sports Governance Act, 2025.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana observed this on Tuesday while hearing the applications filed by some cricket bodies in the BCCI matter. The bench also asked the advocates appearing for the BCCI and state cricket associations to take instructions on why the terms and conditions of service of their office bearers be not gov-



erned by the 2025 Act which is now in force. The apex court is dealing with a plea concerning the BCCI since 2014 and several applications are filed in the matter from time to time.

The top court had earlier constituted a committee headed by former CJI Justice RM Lodha to suggest reform measures, including framing of a constitution for the cash-rich cricket body.

Delhi HC seeks WFI's stand on Phogat's petition

APIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday sought the stand of Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) on a plea by grappler Vinesh Phogat seeking permission to participate in the women's selection trials for the 2026 Senior World Championships.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma asked the counsel for WFI to get instructions on the issue and listed the application for hearing on Thursday.

Phogat, in her application filed in a pending petition, also sought a stay on the operation and implementation of a September 7 circular issued by the WFI prescribing the eligibility criteria for the selection trials



which are scheduled for September 14 at Indira Gandhi Stadium here. The fresh application was filed in the main petition in which the wrestler has sought formulation of a fair and structured framework for women athletes returning to competitive sports after pregnancy and maternity leave. In the application, she has sought a stay on the circular as it excludes her from participating in the selection trials for the championship scheduled to be

held at Astana, Kazakhstan from October 24 to November 1.

The WFI circular provides for women's trial in six Olympic weight categories. Phogat contended that the latest selection framework creates a closed pathway by making eligibility dependent on participation and performance in specified qualifying competitions.

The plea said the circular places Phogat in a position where she is excluded not because she has been assessed and found wanting on sporting merit, but because she was unable to participate in the particular competitions selected by WFI as gateways to the present selection trials.

It said the framework contains no mechanism to account for an athlete who

was unable to participate in the prescribed competitions for maternity-related reasons.

On September 1, the high court sought response of WFI and the Centre on Phogat's plea seeking formulation of a fair and structured framework for women athletes returning to competitive sports after pregnancy and maternity leave. It was listed for further hearing on November 18.

In the petition, she has sought directions for formulation of a fair and structured framework for women athletes returning from maternity, transparent and objectively verifiable selection and nomination processes, and an alternative mechanism for athletes disadvantaged by maternity-related absence.

Central information commission penalises two railway officials ₹20,000 for wrongful RTI denial

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has fined two railway officials a total of ₹20,000 for failing to handle an RTI application properly and not discharging their statutory responsibilities. It also ordered that a caution issued to the then first appellate authority over his handling of the RTI plea be noted in his service record, observing that existing records cannot be mechanically denied.

The officers had denied an RTI plea, saying it was outside the scope of Section



2(f) of the RTI Act, 2005.

The commission imposed a penalty of ₹15,000 on the present Central Public Information Officer (CPIO) of Southern Railway and ₹5,000 on the then CPIO

under Section 20(1) of the RTI Act. The RTI applicant had sought complete file relating to his charge sheet, including correspondence, notes and remarks, apart from details of his revision petition and

action taken on his request for its early disposal.

The CIC said the information sought "pertains to his own disciplinary proceedings and revision petition" and substantially related to information held by or under the control of the public authority. Such requests, it said, "cannot be summarily rejected by invoking Section 2(f) of the RTI Act, 2005".

During the hearing, the present CPIO failed to provide a "cogent or plausible explanation" as to why the information sought was considered outside the scope of Section 2(f), the commission said.



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Gold rises to ₹1.52 lakh/10g



Gold prices on Wednesday rose by ₹190 to ₹1.52 lakh per 10 grams in futures trade as speculators created fresh positions on firm spot demand. On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the yellow metal contract for the October delivery traded higher by Rs 190, or 0.12 per cent, at ₹1,52,769 per 10 grams in a business turnover of 635 lots. Fresh positions by market participants led to a rise in the precious metal's prices, analysts said. Gold futures rose 0.65 per cent to \$4,384.16 per ounce in New York..

(PTI)

CaratLane aims for strong retail footprint expansion



Omnichannel jewellery retailer CaratLane on Wednesday said it plans to open five to seven new stores across Eastern India over the coming months and add 40-50 outlets nationally in FY27, as the Tata group firm looks to strengthen its retail presence in key markets. Currently, it has a national retail network of more than 388 stores, including 69 in Eastern India. The company said the expansion would be supported by investments in its retail network, product portfolio and omnichannel capabilities.

(PTI)

RUPEE PLUNGES 34 PAISE TO 95.08 AGAINST DOLLAR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

The rupee slumped by 34 paise to close at 95.08 (provisional) against the American currency on Wednesday as crude prices crossed the \$100 per barrel mark, stoking concerns over inflation and high forex outflows. Weak equity markets and FI outflows also pressurised the rupee, forex traders said. Brent crude futures surpassed \$100 a barrel for the first time in almost six weeks after attacks on oil facilities and ships in West Asia threatened to weaken the already strained supply chain amid the US-Iran tensions. Brent crude was trading higher by 2.94 per cent at \$100.73 per barrel.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee



opened at 94.80, also its intra-day high, against the US dollar. The local unit fell to an intraday low of 95.22 as crude oil prices surged. The rupee settled at 95.08 (provisional), down 34 paise from its previous close of 94.74.

An appreciation of Lekha Chakraborty's Gender budgeting: That Fire in My Belly



JANET L YELLEN

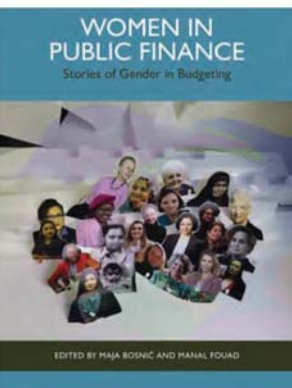
Economists are trained to keep personal experience separate from analysis. But the questions we choose to study often reflect what we have seen in our own lives. Lekha Chakraborty's chapter shows how personal experience led her to an important question, and how careful research helped move it from the margins of public finance toward the mainstream. Her chapter intertwines two stories. She describes growing up in Kerala after her father sent her mother a divorce notice by inland letter late in her second pregnancy. Her mother, a Government hospital nurse, continued working and raised two children alone. The second story concerns gender budgeting in India, a field Professor

Chakraborty entered in 2000. Early meetings often left her shaken because the issues felt inseparable from her mother's experience. Over time, she learned to translate that understanding into evidence and policy analysis. I found her response to institutional resistance especially instructive, with a lesson for anyone seeking to change an established field. Her first presentation met with strong resistance. Senior colleagues urged her institute's director to scale back the project, arguing that gender was not central to public finance and dismissing the care economy as elitist. She responded by developing models, assembling data, and estimating the effects of gender-responsive budget policies on human development. The Ministry of Finance was receptive because she presented the case in terms it understood and could incorporate into its work. In my experience, public institutions rarely change course simply because they are told they should. Durable



change requires evidence, persistence, and an understanding of how institutions make decisions. Professor Chakraborty showed that the values motivating her work could be supported by rigorous economic analysis. That combination gave her argument credibility and influence.

The economic case is now more widely understood. Budgets that appear neutral can affect women and men differently. For a labor economist, unpaid care work is directly relevant to fiscal



policy. Access to child care, water, electricity, transportation, and health care affects whether women can undertake paid employment and what jobs they can hold. Amartya Sen's work on missing women demonstrated the human consequences of gender inequality. Professor Chakraborty helped show how taxing and spending decisions can reinforce or reduce it. Her chapter also emphasizes the importance of making reform part of routine policymaking. India adopted

gender budgeting in 2004, followed by the Gender Budget Statement in 2005-06. Implementation required budget circulars, a methodology manual, and training for representatives of twenty-nine states. These administrative details determine whether a promising idea takes hold. Her international work also demonstrates why reforms must be adapted to national and local institutions. Important work remains. Gender budgeting is established on the expenditure side in India, but intergovernmental fiscal transfers have received less attention. Professor Chakraborty also rightly connects gender budgeting to fiscal consolidation. When Governments reduce deficits, care, health, education, and other investments in human development can be particularly vulnerable. The composition of fiscal adjustment matters alongside the headline change in the deficit. I was particularly moved by her observation that gender

budgeting, and the scholars working on it, gave her a way to understand and describe what had happened to her mother and herself. Economic frameworks help us move from individual experience to questions we can examine systematically. Here, that process produced research with practical consequences for millions of women. Professor Chakraborty writes that she may one day produce a book for young girls. I hope she does. Until then, this chapter deserves to be read by students and young economists who worry that their most compelling question has no accepted place in their field. Her experience shows that personal conviction can sustain a serious and consequential program of economic research.

The author served as the 78th United States Secretary of the Treasury from 2021 to 2025 and as chair of the Federal Reserve from 2014 to 2018. She was the first woman to hold either position, and has also led the White House Council of Economic Advisers

Coforge chairman OP Bhatt resigns after audit flags board evaluation gaps

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

IT services firm Coforge on Wednesday said its Chairperson and Independent Director OP Bhatt has resigned with immediate effect after an internal audit flagged concerns over the manner in which a 'board evaluation report' was handled and presented, including non-disclosure of certain material information, to the board. Among a clutch of filings, Coforge asserted that the board evaluation exercise conducted in March/April 2026 for the previous year does not relate to the company's financial statements or financial matters. The company also clarified that the issue does not have any bearing on the



company's operations and business performance in the near, mid or long term

guidance. In another filing, the company said its internal auditor, as part of the audit

plan for the second quarter of FY26, reviewed the process followed for the board evaluation exercise under Bhatt's guidance and the resulting Board Evaluation Report (BER) presented by him to the board. In simple terms, a board evaluation report refers to a document that assesses performance of the board members. "The review identified certain concerns in relation to the manner in which the BER had been dealt with and presented to the board," Coforge said, adding that certain material information contained in or relating to the BER report and the performance of the chairman had not been fully disclosed to the board when the report was presented.

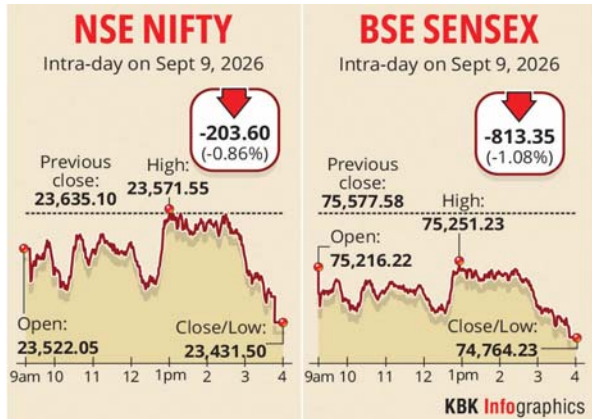
Sensex tumbles 813 points to 3-month low amid West Asia tension

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

Falling for the third straight day, benchmark stock index Sensex tumbled 813 points to a three-month low, and the Nifty settled below 23,450 following selling in IT, FMCG, financial services and oil & gas shares, as escalating tensions in West Asia drove crude oil to over \$100 per barrel. The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 813.35 points, or 1.08 per cent, to settle at the day's low of 74,764.23, also the lowest closing level in nearly three months. The 50-share NSE Nifty declined 203.60 points, or

0.86 per cent, to end at a nearly three-month low of 23,431.50. The index had closed near this level on June 11 previously. Among the 30 Sensex firms, HCL Tech fell the most, down 4.55 per cent. Infosys dropped 4.43 per cent, Tech Mahindra by 3.87 per cent, and Tata Consultancy Services by 2.26 per cent. HDFC Bank and Hindustan Unilever were also among the major laggards. Adani Ports was the lead gainer, rising by 3.67 per cent. Tata Steel, Trent and NTPC were among the winners. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 2.67 per



cent to \$100.5 per barrel.

"Indian equity markets extended their decline for a third consecutive session,

with benchmark indices ending firmly lower as persistent selling pressure and a broad risk-off mood kept

sentiment subdued. Elevated crude oil prices, lingering geopolitical tensions and a sharp rise in market volatility continued to weigh on investor confidence, reinforcing the market's prevailing bearish undertone," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said. India VIX climbed more than 6 per cent, reflecting increased hedging activity and growing caution over the near-term outlook, he added. The BSE SmallCap Select index declined 0.59 per cent and the MidCap Select index dipped 0.52 per cent.

Indian industry need diversification in services: Commerce Secretary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

The Indian industry needs to diversify its services exports beyond the two dominant segments of IT/ITes and professional services to achieve sustainable growth, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal said here on Wednesday. Addressing a session at the Global Fintech Fest 2026, he also said the global financial services is growing and stand at around \$670 billion, but India's share is just \$8 billion, which is just over one per cent of the global trade. "Fintechs here can make the change...Out of the \$8 billion, 95 per cent is digitally delivered financial services... Services which are delivered cross border sitting back in your country, so that is probably the strength of India and that is where we are growing. So



now it is the time... we need to be diversified through use of technology," he said. He added that the country's services exports are registering healthy growth. Out of the total \$863 billion exports in 2025-26, \$421 billion was contributed by the services segment. The secretary said that one of the key challenges of the country's services exports growth story has been that it is more con-

centrated on two pillars — IT/ITes and professional services. IT/ITes-based services account for about 50 per cent of India's total exports, while professional services constitute another 30 per cent. "So these are the two pillars on which our services exports are based right now but it needs diversification if we have to grow and if we have to grow sustainably for a long period of time, we need diversification," Agarwal said. He added that India has the potential to provide a bouquet of services to the world. He also suggested to look at ways to reduce transactions and cost of remittances. The global cross border payment market is about \$182-190 billion and is projected to reach \$350-360 billion by 2032. Similarly the cards and payments, which at present is around \$1 trillion, is expected to reach \$1.5 trillion by 2028-29.

Indian economy doing reasonably well, it will regain it's mojo: NITI Aayog VC Lahiri

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

NITI Aayog Vice Chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri on Wednesday said the Indian economy has been doing reasonably well and that Asia's third-largest economy will regain its mojo and return to a current account surplus soon. Lahiri further said the major challenge the Indian economy faces is the low share of manufacturing in India's overall GDP. "The Indian economy has been doing reasonably well. I will never say very well because I am a reformist," he said at the Global Fintech Fest 2026. India's economy grew at a faster-than-expected 7.8 per cent in the April-June quarter, showing resilience despite concerns that the war in Iran and resulting global uncertainty could weigh on domestic economic momentum. On foreign investment in India, Lahiri said domestic savings, not foreign savings, must do most of the heavy lifting. He explained that in the early part of the 19th century, the United States imported capital from Europe, while East Asia consistently ran current account surpluses because it had



foreign direct investment and foreign portfolio investment, but most of the investment was financed by domestic savings. "We will regain our mojo, and I think we will generate current account surpluses soon ... we used to worry about the 3 per cent rule. If current account deficit exceeds 3 per cent of GDP, then all hell will break loose," Lahiri said. For fiscal 2025-26, the current account deficit stood at USD 25.2 billion, or 0.6 per cent of GDP, compared to USD 22.9 billion, or 0.6 per cent of GDP, in 2024-25. He said that, normally, when GDP goes up, the share of agriculture goes down, and the share of industry, which includes, apart from manufacturing, some others, and services goes up. "But if you look at the

developed countries, manufacturing has gone down, but manufacturing has gone down at a much higher per capita income than what was threatening to be a problem," Lahiri said. The NITI Aayog Vice Chairman pointed out that India's recent GDP data shows that the share of manufacturing in the GDP has gone up. "But we need much more manufacturing now," he said. Lahiri said foreign players coming into the country and the number of investments that are happening in the renewable side, data centre, semiconductor and electronic manufacturing system, is very positive. Responding to a question on India's banking sector, he said credit appraisal, a major job of every bank manager, is tough. "I think credit appraisal can be done much more efficiently, whereby you can assess the risk and you can do a better risk pricing," Lahiri said. The NITI Aayog Vice Chairman emphasised that bankers must find a way to use the rich data UPI is generating for credit appraisal and better risk pricing, and include the informal sector, particularly MSMEs, in the formal credit system.

FROM THE WORLD

USA

Facebook trial begins on polls

Facebook is on trial in New Mexico over privacy concerns that emerged during the 2016 election when a political consulting firm bought user data that was harvested from millions of profiles to generate targeted ads.

Opening statements will begin Wednesday in state court in Santa Fe, just weeks after 48 US states reached a landmark settlement with Meta. Florida was the only other state that didn't sign the settlement, claiming it wasn't tough enough on the social media conglomerate.

"Facebook's data breach didn't just expose private information, it revealed a pattern of misrepresentation about how user data was collected," New Mexico Attorney General Raul Torrez said in a statement Tuesday.

CANADA

Ammy Virk escapes unhurt

Punjabi singer Ammy Virk escaped unhurt after a vehicle in his concert convoy came under gunfire in Abbotsford, Canada, local media reported. The attack took place soon after Virk's concert at the Rogers Forum on September 5 in British Columbia province.Canadian media outlets Vancouver Sun and Abbotsford News reported the shootout, quoting local police officials.

Freedom of navigation should remain pivotal priorities: Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Wednesday said that secure sea lanes, freedom of navigation, respect for international law and unhindered maritime trade should remain pivotal priorities as they are crucial for the growth and prosperity of the Indian Ocean Region.

Singh made the remarks at a public event after he held an “extremely productive” meeting with Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Dissanayake during which they reaffirmed that as civilisational twins, close neighbours and maritime partners, India and Sri Lanka would continue to work jointly to ensure the safety, security, peace and prosperity of the region. Speaking on 'India-Sri Lanka Maritime Cooperation in the Indian Ocean Region-



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh being accorded a Guard of Honour during his visit to the Ministry of Defence of Sri Lanka

Civilisational Partners with intertwined destinies' in Colombo, Singh said that Indian and Sri Lankan ports can become engines of shared economic growth, while

their maritime industries can become the drivers for the future prosperity of the region.

“Together, India and Sri Lanka are well positioned to serve as the

closest partners in safeguarding peace, security and stability across the Indian Ocean Region,” he said.

Singh, who arrived in Colombo on Tuesday for a three-day visit, becoming the first Indian defence minister to visit Sri Lanka in 38 years, said that freedom of navigation and ensuring open trade routes are crucial for the growth and prosperity of the region.

“Therefore, secure sea lanes, freedom of navigation, respect for international law, unhindered maritime trade and commerce should remain our pivotal priorities,” he said.

“It is essential that we work together towards shaping a favourable, secure maritime environment, remaining ready to address emerging maritime challenges in the first instance, before they become a serious threat to

our developmental interests and the bright future of our region,” he said. Singh said that Sri Lanka occupies a salient strategic location in the Indian Ocean Region, overlooking a vast ocean characterised by crisscrossing busy trade routes. “These routes are not only the arteries for global trade, but also determine the trajectory of our growth and development as well as the safety and security of our region,” he said.

Today, the Indian Ocean is not merely a waterway, but the stage on which the economic and strategic future of our region will be written, he said. “For India and Sri Lanka, both maritime nations bound by this shared ocean, this is not a matter of abstract theory but of lived, everyday reality - one that shapes our trade, our security and our destinies alike,” he said.

Sri Lanka, like India, is undoubtedly central to any strategic discourse on maritime security in the Indian Ocean Region, the minister said. “In Sri Lanka, India sees a friendly neighbour, a longstanding friend and a reliable partner. India-Sri Lanka Maritime Cooperation is thus not only mutually beneficial but quintessential to our collective safety and security,” Singh said.

“In a rapidly changing geopolitical landscape, the Indian Ocean has come to occupy a place of immense contemporary relevance. As emerging economies and fellow democracies, we have a shared future,” he said.

Singh said India would be delighted to share its experience and work closely with Sri Lanka for the continued growth and prosperity of the region.

Singapore police probe five over racist comments on Nepal floods, Air India

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

Singapore police have questioned five people over the alleged racist comments online related to the Nepal floods and Singapore Airlines' (SIA) investment in Air India.

This follows Senior Minister K Shanmugam's announcement on Saturday that the police were looking into the “shameful” racist and xenophobic online comments about the Nepal-Tibet flash floods disaster and SIA's investment in Air India.

According to Channel News Asia, police on Wednesday confirmed they received reports and are investigating certain online comments related to both matters. Five people, aged between 29 and 66, have been identified and interviewed in connection with these comments, police



said. “We will continue to investigate and identify those responsible for these online comments.” Police said they take a serious view of conduct that may hurt racial feelings or incite hostility and ill will between different racial groups. As investigations are ongoing, police are unable to comment further on the specifics of individual cases, they added. Shanmugam, the Home Affairs Minister, on Saturday gave several examples of racist remarks made online about the missing

Singaporeans, including “No they are not our own”, “I only see Indian faces here. Skip. Rescue cut”, and “All ABNNs look the same, how to AI?” He noted that “ABNN” is a derogatory term for Indians.

More than a thousand people have died, and Singaporeans remained unaccounted for, he said, yet such remarks continued to circulate online. News that Air India is seeking fresh equity from shareholders, including SIA, also sparked a new wave of “anti-Indian, racist ranting”, Shanmugam said.

The SIA holds a 25.1 per cent stake in Air India through a partnership with the Tata Group. Shanmugam said the Ministry of Digital Development and Information will ask social media platforms to remove comments that breach guidelines.

Rajnath visits IPKF memorial in Colombo

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Wednesday visited the Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF) memorial in Colombo and paid homage to the soldiers who laid down their lives in the call of duty.

Singh arrived in Sri Lanka on Tuesday on a three-day visit. “Visited to the IPKF memorial in Colombo and paid homage to our valiant soldiers who laid down their lives in the call of duty. The nation will never forget their supreme sacrifice. They will remain a source of inspiration for the generations to come,” the minister posted



on X. The IPKF was a military contingent sent by India to Sri Lanka in July 1987 as part of efforts to disarm the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), a separatist militant organisation, and maintain peace and stability in the region.

The memorial pays tribute to the 1,155 Indian soldiers who served in the IPKF and made the ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. Singh also visited the Sri Lankan Ministry of Defence and interacted

with the senior military leadership of the country.

“During my visit to the Ministry of Defence of Sri Lanka, I had an opportunity to interact with the senior military leadership of Sri Lanka. Many of them have been trained in India and share a close bond with Bharat,” he said in a post on X. “In my brief remarks, I underscored the vision MAHASAGAR for ‘mutual’ and ‘holistic’ growth and reiterated our desire to further strengthen the longstanding India-Sri Lanka defence and strategic partnership with special emphasis on maritime cooperation,” he added.

Warehouse explosion in Syria kills at least 14

OMAR ALBAM ■ Sarmada

An explosion at a weapons warehouse in northwestern Syria killed at least 14 people and injured 11 others, state media reported Wednesday, citing the Health Ministry.

The cause of the blast near the town of Sarmada, in Idlib province, was not immediately clear. Such incidents are a relatively common occurrence in the country, which has been battered by over a decade of



war. The warehouse was used to store weapons and munitions left over from the

country's uprising and civil war from 2011 until 2024, the state-run SANA news agency

said, citing the Defense Ministry, without providing further details.

Civil Defense and Syrian Red Crescent first-responders are continuing to search for survivors trapped under the rubble. A photographer for The Associated Press at the scene saw bodies being recovered. Video footage widely circulated after the blast showed a large plume of black smoke, while the sounds of smaller explosions could be heard. (AP)

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Johnny S/o Malkeet Singh R/o III-B/76 Vishnu Garden, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi - 110018 have changed my name to Joni Singh.

I, Mukesh Kumar S/o Sita Ram Meena R/o 37A, Surya Kunj, Najafgarh, South West Delhi, Delhi-110043 declare that name of my mine and my wife has been wrongly written as Mukesh and Rekha in my minor son Himnish Kumar aged 13 years in his school records. The actual name of mine and my wife are Mukesh Kumar and Rekha Meena, which may be amended accordingly.

I, Aanaanda, Father of- No.15573892N Hav Pankaj Aanaanda Mali, R/o- At PO Ajang, Teh & Dist- Dhule, Maharashtra- 424301, have changed my name from Aanaanda to Aanaanda Ram Bhau Mali, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Kusum Bai, Mother of- No. 15573892N Hav Pankaj Aanaanda Mali, R/o- At PO Ajang, Teh & Dist- Dhule, Maharashtra- 424301, have changed my name from Kusum Bai to Kusumbai Aanaanda Mali, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Vaishali, W/o No. 15573892N Hav Pankaj Aanaanda Mali, R/o- At PO Ajang, Teh & Dist- Dhule, Maharashtra- 424301, have changed my name from Vaishali to Vaishali Pankaj Mali, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Choudhari Ranjana, M/o No.14938659Y Hav Chaudhari Amol Balasaheb, R/o- Vill- Naigaonpeth (Wadchiwadi) Teh- Haveli, Dist- Pune, Maharashtra- 412110, have changed my name & D.O.B from Choudhari Ranjana 01.07.1963 to Ranjana Balasaheb Choudhari 01.07.1962 vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Aanaanda, Father of- No.15573892N Hav Pankaj Aanaanda Mali, R/o- At PO Ajang, Teh & Dist- Dhule, Maharashtra- 424301, have changed my name from Aanaanda to Aanaanda Ram Bhau Mali, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Sulekha, Mother of No.16023597H Nk Rahul Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Pamnawali, Teh- Khatauli, Dist- Muzaffarnagar, U.P.- 251201, have changed my name from Sulekha to Sukhika, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Prabhawti Devi, Mother of No. 4294543L Nk Manish Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill- Sahasrarawon, PO- & P.S- Asoan, Dist & Teh- Siwan, Bihar- 841287, have changed my name from Prabhawti Devi to Prabhavati Devi, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.15571828X RHM Anil Kumar, R/o- Vill- Rampayali (Kasvitola), Post- Rampayali, Teh- Warseoni, Dist- Balaghat, Madhya Pradesh- 481335, have changed my daughter's name from Shriya to Shriya Dhuware, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.15571828X RHM Anil Kumar, R/o- Vill- Rampayali (Kasvitola), Post- Rampayali, Teh- Warseoni, Dist- Balaghat, Madhya Pradesh- 481335, have changed my son's name from Gaurav to Gaurav Dhuware, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.15421491P Nk Sateesh Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Singha, Teh- Chandpur, Dist- Bijnor, U.P.- 246725 declare that Omwati is my mother. In my service record her D.O.B is wrongly mentioned as 15/10/1956 whereas her correct DOB is 01/01/1949 which may be amended accordingly.

I, Radha Kanta Das, Father of- No.14642968A CHM Badal Kumar Das, R/o- Vill- Sitibinda, PO- Saharda, Dist- Paschim Medinipur, W.B.- 721131, have changed my name from Radha Kanta Das to Lakshikanta Das, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Mineshwari, W/o No.14939822A Hav Kakade Ananda Pralhadrao, R/o- Pimpalgaon (Dhage), Po- Karegaon, Teh- Loha, Dist- Nanded, Maharashtra- 431708 have changed my name & D.O.B from Girja Bai 05.04.1967 to Girjabai Pralhad Kakade 01.01.1952 vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Kolehkar Surekha Somanath, W/o- No.15749901P SIGMN Kolehkar Somanath Shivaji, R/o- At- Rayewadi, Post- Karewadi, Tel- Kavathemahankal, Dist- Sangli, Maharashtra- 416403, have changed my name from Kolehkar Surekha Somanath to Surekha Somanath Kolehkar, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.14830872P Hav Jahenda Singh Baghel, R/o- Vill & PO- Chiruli, Teh- Dabra, Dist- Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh- 475005, declare that due to some inadvertence, my mother's name has not been recorded in my service records; my mother's name is Sumintra Bai which may be updated in my service records.

I, Manawati Devi, Mother of No. 14854393M Hav Sanjeev Kumar Pal, R/o- Vill- Satwat, Po- Eraura Ps- Deo, Distt- Aurangabad State- Bihar Pin- 824216 have changed my name from Manawati Devi to Manmatiya Devi, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Bhavnaben, W/o No.15573355H Hav Sagathia Samatbhai, R/o- Vill- Sogathi, PO- Samana, Teh- Jamjodhpur, Dist- Jamnagar, Gujarat - 360520 have changed my name from Bhavnaben to Bhavna Sagathia, vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, hitherto known as Sayyad Gousiya Begum W/O Sayyad Mahaboob Basha, R/O 6-1-425/1, Siva Nagar, Badvel, Badvel, PO: Badvel, Dist: Cuddapah, Andhra Pradesh - 516227, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as S Gausiya Begum.

AXIS BANK LTD.

Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 2nd Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301.

Corporate Office: Axis House, Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025. Registered Office: Trisruti, 3rd floor, opposite Samartheeshwar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006. Also at: Axis Bank Ltd., Hall No-1, PN 1&2, GF, Gaura Residency, Chander Nagar, Ghaziabad, UP-201011

DEMAND NOTICE

Notice is hereby given under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, a demand notice was issued on the dates mentioned against each account and stated hereinafter calling upon them to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice. The Borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of power conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the said Act on the dates mentioned against each account. The Borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount and interest thereon. The borrowers attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.

Sr. No.	Name of Borrower / Co-borrower / Guarantor	(1) Date of Demand Notice (Rs.)	(2) Date of Possession (Rs.)
1.	1. Mrs Steel Mart through its Prop. Mrs. Neha Balyan (Borrower) F-80, Sector-83, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar, UP-201305 2. Mrs. Neha Balyan (Proprietor) A 1/1704, Saya Apartment, Ahinsa Khand-2, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, UP-201014, 3. Mr. Satender Kumar (Guarantor/Mortgagor) S/o. Moji Ram, H. No. 464/87, South Civil Line, Sunam Vihar, Muzaffar Nagar, UP-251092 4. Mr. Vijay Balyan (Guarantor), A 1/1704, Saya Zenith, Ahinsa Khand-2, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, UP-201014	(1) 16-Jun-2026 (2) 08-Sep-2026 (3) Rs. 17,56,123/- (Rupees Seventy Lakh Fifty Six Thousand One Hundred Twenty Three Only)	(1) 13-May-2026 (2) 08-Sep-2026 (3) Rs. 1,19,47,913/- (Rupees One Crore Nineteen Lakh Forty Seven Thousand Nine Hundred Thirteen Only)

PROPERTY ADD: Residential Property bearing H. No. 464/87, South Civil Line, having land area measuring 137.08 Square Yards (i.e. 114.60 Square Meters), situated at Mohalla Sunam Vihar, Village Muzaffarnagar, Pargana, Tehsil & District Muzaffarnagar, Uttar Pradesh, owned by Mr. Satendra Kumar vide Sale Deed No. 3817 dated 15-May-1991. Boundaries: North: Plot of Saller, West: Plot of Saller, South: Basha, East: Plot of Iktbal Singh

1.	1. Mr. Rajesh Vashist (Applicant), S/o Mr. Lokender Vashist, H. No. G-48, Top Floor, Preet Vihar, G-Block, Delhi-110092. Also at: H. No. 48, Ganesh Nagar-2 Ext., Shakarpur, Delhi-110092. 2. Mr. Divyanshu Vashist (Co-Applicant), S/o Mr. Rajesh Vashist, H. No. 48, Ganesh Nagar-2 Ext., Shakarpur, Delhi-110092. 3. Mrs. Anuradha Vashisti (Co-Applicant), W/o Rajesh Vashist, H. No. 48, Ganesh Nagar-2 Ext., Shakarpur, Delhi-110092	(1) 13-May-2026 (2) 08-Sep-2026 (3) Rs. 1,19,47,913/- (Rupees One Crore Nineteen Lakh Forty Seven Thousand Nine Hundred Thirteen Only)
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PROPERTY ADD: Entire Third Floor with Roof Rights, except Common Area, measuring 208 Sq. Yds. i.e. 173.88 Sq. Mtrs., having its plinth/covered area 130.41 Sq. Mtrs., along with one car parking as indicated inside the property, with common stair, passage, entrance, main gate, along with proportionate share in land underneath with all other common facilities/amenities which are provided in the said building, a part of property bearing No. G-40, Plot No. 48 in Block-G, situated in the layout plan of Preet Vihar, Delhi-110092. Boundaries: East: As per Title Deed; West: As per Title Deed; North: As per Title Deed; South: As per Title Deed

Dated: 10-Sep-2026, Place: Delhi MCR

Sd/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

The Chief Administrative Officer/Const., Northern Railway, Kashmir Gate, Delhi, for and on behalf of the President of India invites **Open e-tender under Two Packet System** of the under noted work :-

1.	Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Agreement for construction of 3rd and 4th Railway line adjacent to the existing Broad Gauge (BG) electrified double line including Civil Engineering works, Track works, Signalling & Telecommunication works, Over Head Electrification, Electrical General services & all other allied works between Delhi Subjemandi (SZM) to Ambala Cantt (UMB) in Delhi & Ambala divisions of Northern Railway.
2.	Approx. Cost of work
3.	Completion period of the work
4.	Earnest Money to be deposited
5.	Sale/availability of tender document on Rly. Website
6.	(i) Pre-Bid Conference
7.	Last date of receipt of queries
8.	Authority response to queries
9.	Last date/Time of upload of tenders
10.	Date and time of opening of technical bid
Tender Notice No. 74-W-4-1-488-WA-MB Dated :- 09.09.2026 3108/2026	

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Zelenskyy urges world to pressure Russia over deaths

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy chided the international community Wednesday for not taking a tougher stance against Russia over its escalating bombardment of civilian areas of Ukraine.

At the end of last month, Russia launched a week of nighttime and daylight attacks on Kyiv in its heaviest sustained bombardment of the Ukrainian Capital since its invasion began more than four years ago.

The relentless missile and drone strikes have continued this month and aim to sap civilian morale, Ukrainian officials say. International economic sanctions on Russia and efforts to isolate Moscow diplomatically haven't stopped the invasion. Zelenskyy called on countries to step up the pressure. "Unfortunately, there has been too little response from the international community to these strikes, which are taking people's lives practically every day," the Ukrainian leader said on social media.

"But a response is needed



— Moscow must not go into the winter believing that it can get away with missile and drone terror without consequences," he said.

The United Nations said last month that due to increasing Russian aerial

attacks, more Ukrainian civilians were killed or wounded in July than in any month since March 2022, with 437 killed and more than 2,600 wounded. In all, more than 16,800 Ukrainian civilians have been killed and more

than 51,000 wounded since Russia's army poured across the border, according to the UN Human Rights Monitoring Mission in Ukraine.

The Russian aerial attacks overnight into Wednesday killed at least two people and

wounded seven, Ukrainian officials said, as Moscow fired ballistic and cruise missiles as well as drones at six regions of Ukraine.

Four of the wounded were in a 22-story residential building in Kyiv's Darnytskyi district, where a drone damaged the 11th floor and started a fire on the 12th floor, Ukraine's State Emergency Service said.

Olha Smal, a 62-year-old who lives on the building's 12th floor, said the blast wave flung her across her kitchen. One of her bedrooms caught fire, and smoke quickly filled the apartment, she said. Her pregnant neighbour was wounded.

"You live one day at a time. You don't know what will happen to you tomorrow, or even what will happen today," she said. "It's very, very hard." Russia's Defence Ministry said that its forces hit a drone factory warehouse in Kyiv. It also claimed strikes on logistical facilities in the southern Ukrainian port city Mykolaiv, fuel reservoirs in the city's port and an electric substation. The Russian military also struck a ship heading to Odesa with mili-

tary cargo and logistical facilities at Ukraine's Starokozache border crossing with Moldova, the ministry said. The border strike killed two people, Ukrainian authorities said. Zelenskyy said Ukraine is responding to Moscow's strikes with daily long-range attacks on infrastructure deep inside Russia.

He said the latest Ukrainian strikes targeted Novorossiysk, a Black Sea port in Russia's Krasnodar region. The attack hit a naval base, including a terminal used to load oil, military port facilities, and warships carrying cruise missiles, according to Zelenskyy.

The Novorossiysk naval base is a key hub for Russia's Black Sea Fleet, providing maintenance and logistical support for its ships, according to Ukraine's General Staff.

Krasnodar Gov. Veniamin Kondratyev said that four people, including a child, were killed and 29 others were wounded in the drone attack on Novorossiysk.

Russia's Defence Ministry said that air defences downed 596 Ukrainian drones from late Tuesday until early Wednesday.

Albania police block protesters over Kushner resort plan



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Tirana

Police in Albania blocked protesters from reaching parliament on Tuesday as the latest rally against a luxury development linked to US President Donald Trump's son-in-law, Jared Kushner, turned violent. The march was staged as parliament resumed from a summer recess and after the

demonstrations marked their 100th day on Monday. They challenged a police cordon in the centre of the capital, Tirana, pelting officers in riot gear with eggs and tomatoes. Cars transporting lawmakers to the parliament building were confronted by the crowds and were hit with plastic water bottles before police intervened to let them through.

Indonesia searches for 8 missing at near Anak volcano

NINIEK KARMINI ■ Jakarta

Indonesian rescuers searched for eight people who went missing at sea while heading to a volcanic island to report on an eruption there, officials said Wednesday.

Anak Krakatau initially erupted for about 25 hours over the weekend, and it has since continued to erupt intermittently with explosions ejecting lava, ash and incandescent volcanic material from the crater, Indonesia's Geology Agency said in a statement on Wednesday. A speedboat carrying five



photojournalists, two crew members and a route guide lost contact after

leaving Carita, a coastal town in Banten province, for the volcanic island, said Al Amrad, Banten province's Search and Rescue Office chief. He said the last message from the boat was received by relatives of a journalist on board at 6:13 pm on Monday, saying the group had arrived in the waters around Anak Krakatau. They have not been heard from since.

The five Indonesian journalists work for Indonesia's state news agency Antara, Turkey's Anadolu Agency, Merdeka and iNews, while the fifth is a freelance photographer. (AP)



MADHYA PRADESH POWER GENERATING COMPANY LIMITED

Superintending Engineer (P&W), Office of The Executive Director (Gen.), Sanjay Gandhi Thermal Power Station, Birsinghpur, Distt.-Umaria-484 552 (M.P.)

E-mail ID : sepnw_sgtpss@mppgcl.mp.gov.in, Fax : 07655-260226
No. 511-0100/SGTPS/P&W/ENIT-21/2026 MPPGC 526051_1/2556
Dated : 08.09.2026

CORRIGENDUM NOTICE

This office has published an E-NIT No. 21/2463 Dtd. 02.09.2026 in two newspapers namely The Pioneer (New Delhi) and Patrika (Bhopal). The estimate and EMD at Sl. No. 3 for Tender ID 2026_MPPGC_526051_1 shall be read as Rs. 1,89,420,17/- and Rs. 2,00,000/- instead of Rs. 2,00,000/- and Rs. 1,89,500/-.

All other terms & conditions of the NIT shall remain unchanged.

For further details, please visit website www.mptenders.gov.in

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (P&W)

M.P. Madhyam/127959/2026

Norway bids final farewell to King as crowds and royals for his funeral

MARKUS SCHREIBER ■ Oslo

Norway was bidding its final farewell to King Harald V on Wednesday as the popular monarch's coffin set off for a funeral attended by royalty and leaders from across Europe and beyond, with thousands of people lining the streets.

A 21-gun salute rang out over Oslo at the start of the procession from the royal palace to Oslo Cathedral. Harald's son, new King Haakon VIII, and other senior royals walked behind the



coffin, draped with the red Norwegian royal standard. Harald, who died on August 28 at age 89, was Europe's oldest monarch and had reigned for 35 years.

He had modernised the royal house, but refused to follow in the footsteps of

other ageing monarchs who have abdicated in recent times. His son immediately became King Haakon VIII and last week pledged an oath of allegiance to Norway's constitution in parliament. Large crowds flocked to the capital for the funeral, and thousands of people stood behind barriers on streets lined with national flags. The downtown area was closed to vehicles and electric scooters, and police have instructed people not to bring bicycles, umbrellas or sharp objects. (AP)

Indian philanthropist reach out to flood-affected communities in Nepal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Kathmandu

Floods in Nepal have disrupted the lives of numerous families, damaging homes, destroying belongings, and creating shortages of essential necessities. During this difficult period, Indian social worker and humanitarian Rahul Gupta has been extending support to flood-affected communities and making efforts to provide relief to families in need.

Gupta has been reaching out to affected residents, understanding their immediate requirements, and providing assistance according to their circumstances. Relief support includes food, drinking water, daily-use essential items, and other necessary supplies for families facing difficulties following the floods. Beyond distributing relief materials, Gupta has also been meeting affected people personally to understand the challenges they are experiencing. Many families are facing difficulties in rebuilding their homes, restoring their livelihoods, and returning to normal life.

Rahul Gupta has extended humanitarian assistance to families affected by the recent floods in Assam, providing essential relief materials and other necessities to help communities cope with the difficult situation. As



part of the relief initiative, essential supplies were distributed among flood-affected families in Sivasagar district, offering immediate support to those facing hardships due to the devastating floods.



SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.

Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051, Regd. Off.: Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN.

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE OF 15 DAYS FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 9(1) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002. NOTICE is hereby given to the Public in General and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below listed immovable properties ("Secured Assets") mortgaged / charged to the Secured Creditor, the Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of "SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. (hereinafter referred to as SMHFC) ("Secured Creditor"), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on the date and time mentioned herein below, for recovery of the dues mentioned herein below and further interest and other expenses thereon till date of realization, due to SMHFC Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below :-

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of the Properties	Reserve Price : Earnest Money Deposit :	Date & Time of E-Auction	Date of EMD Submission
LAN : 611539211066117		All The Piece and Parcel of The Property / House Measuring Area 310 Sq. Yards, i. e. 0-10 Maria Being 5/172 Share Out 17 Kanal 04 Maria, Comprised in Khewat No. 5, Khaton No. 10, Kharsa No. 22/2/2(4-0), 3/2 (2-0), 8 (8-0) and 22/9/11(3-14), Kitta 2, As Per Jamabandi For The Year 2018-2019, HB No. 138, Situated At: Mouja Mandoli, Tehsil : Jagadhari, District : Yamunagar Recorded In The Name of Javed Khan, S/o. Iqbal Khan As Per Sale Deed Bearing Wasika No. 1040 Dated 09.05.2022. > Bounded As Under - East : Road; West : Property of Rehamin; North : Property of Other Owner; South : Property of Rehamin.	Rs. 9,50,000/-	30.09.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	29.09.2026
1.	Javed Khan, S/o. Iqbal Khan				
2.	Reshma Javed Khan, W/o. Javed Khan		Rs. 95,000/-		

Details terms and conditions of the sale are as below and the details are also provided in our/secured creditor's website at the following link website address (<https://BidDeal.in> and <https://www.grihashakti.com/pdf/E-Auction.pdf>) The Intending Bidders can also contact : Hanuwant Singh, Mobile: 9988898312, E-mail : Hanuwant.Singh@grihashakti.com, Mr. Niloy Dey, on his Mob. 8655619157, E-mail : Niloy.Dey@grihashakti.com

Place : Yamunagar, Haryana
Date : 10.09.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.



Office of The Superintending Engineer 9th Circle, Public Work Department Dehradun

Website - <http://pwd.uk.gov.in> E-Mail : sepwdddun09@gmail.com

Letter No.- 60771/C-9/2026

NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING

Date 09.09.2026

e-tender Notice

The Superintending Engineer 9th Circle, Public Works Department, Dehradun on behalf of "Governor of Uttarakhand" invites tender in two bid system for the following work. Information regarding tender shall be available on <https://www.uktenders.gov.in> from date **11.09.2026**

Sl. NO.	Name of work	Earnest money (Rs. In Lacs)	Cost of Tender Document (In Rs.)	Validity of Tender (In days)	Period of Completion (In Month)	Contractor Category of Registration
1	Construction work of interlocking tiles on damaged internal roads in Sumeru vihar, Village Selaqui, Village Ummedpur, Village Ambiwala, Village Thakurpur and Village Khusalpur in the Sahaspur Constituency of Dehradun District under State Sector.	6.94	5000.00 + 18% GST	90	12	Registered in 'A' & above category in Road works in Central Govt. /State Govt/any Govt. Undertaking



The Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited

Impaired Assets Recovery Centre, Delhi
Plot No. 132-134, Sector-44 Gurgaon, Haryana.

email- lardel@jkmail.com | P 0124-4715800 (Extn- 105 & 842)

E-Auction Notice

(For sale of immovable property/ies under the SARFAESI Act, 2002)

"Appendix, IV-A, Refer Proviso to Rule 8(6)"

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and to the borrowers and guarantors in particular that the below mentioned property mortgaged to secured creditor (Jammu & Kashmir Bank Ltd), the possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of the Secured Creditor (Jammu & Kashmir Bank Ltd) under Section 13(4) of the SARFAESI Act, will be sold through E-auction on "AS IS WHERE IS" "AS IS WHAT IS" AND "WHATEVER THERE IS" basis on below mentioned dates, for recovery of amount as mentioned below due to the secured creditor from concerned borrower(s), mortgagor(s) and guarantors. The Reserve Price is mentioned below and earnest money to be deposited is mentioned respectively.

Name & Address of Borrower/ Guarantors	M/S Polo Amusement Park Ltd, C/o Fun- 'N' Food Village, old Delhi, Gurugram Road, Kapashera, New Delhi Through its Directors:- 1) Sh. Balwant Singh Chawla & 2) Sh. Santokh Singh Chawla. • Mr Balwant Singh Chawla, S/o Mr Sewa Singh, R/O Farm No 6A, Ansal Farms Near MCD Toll, Salahuddin Village, Bijwasan, New Delhi – 110061. Also, R/o D-801, Surya Vihar, Gurgaon, Haryana-122016 (Borrower/Director cum Mortgagor cum Personal Guarantor). • Mr. Santokh Singh Chawla S/o Mr Sewa Singh, R/O Farm No 6A, Ansal Farms Near MCD Toll, Salahuddin Village, Bijwasan, New Delhi – 110061 (Borrower/Director cum Mortgagor cum Personal Guarantor).	M/S Polo Amusement Park Ltd, C/o Fun- 'N' Food Village, old Delhi, Gurugram Road, Kapashera, New Delhi Through its Directors:- 1) Sh. Balwant Singh Chawla & 2) Sh. Santokh Singh Chawla. • Mr Balwant Singh Chawla, S/o Mr Sewa Singh, R/O Farm No 6A, Ansal Farms Near MCD Toll, Salahuddin Village, Bijwasan, New Delhi – 110061. Also, R/o D-801, Surya Vihar, Gurgaon, Haryana-122016 (Borrower/Director cum Mortgagor cum Personal Guarantor). • Mr. Santokh Singh Chawla S/o Mr Sewa Singh, R/O Farm No 6A, Ansal Farms Near MCD Toll, Salahuddin Village, Bijwasan, New Delhi – 110061 (Borrower/Director cum Mortgagor cum Personal Guarantor).
Details of Security Charged covered under Auction	Property being Apartment No. 701 on 7th Floor, Building No. E, Having Covered Area Of 1640 Sq. Ft. Surya Vihar, Dundhera, Sector 21, District Gurgaon, Haryana, in the name of M/s Polo Amusement Park Limited.	Property Being Apartment No. 702, on 7th Floor, Building No. E, Having Covered Area Of 1640 Sq. Ft. Surya Vihar, Dundhera, Sector 21, District Gurgaon, Haryana, in the name of Mr. Santokh Singh.
Reserve price	Rs.147.00 Lacs (Rupees One Hundred Forty-seven Lacs only)	Rs.147.00 Lacs (Rupees One Hundred Forty-seven Lacs only)
EMD Amount	Rs.14.70 Lacs (Rupees Fourteen lacs and seventy thousand only)	Rs.14.70 Lacs (Rupees Fourteen lacs and seventy thousand only)
Bid Increment	Rs. 1.00 Lacs (Rupees One Lac only)	Rs. 1.00 Lacs (Rupees One Lac only)
Outstanding Dues	Rs.4,32,52,893.35 (Rupees Four Crore Thirty two Lacs fifty two thousand eight hundred ninety three and paise thirty-five only) as on 31.08.2026.	Rs.4,32,52,893.35 (Rupees Four Crore Thirty two Lacs fifty two thousand eight hundred ninety three and paise thirty-five only) as on 31.08.2026.

Name & Number of Contact Person & Branch	Mr. Reyaz Ahmad Mir (Authorized Officer) Email id: reyaz.mir@jkmail.com Mobile No. 9906980479 & Branch Manager Mr. Mufti Wajid Yaqub (Branch Office, Vasant Vihar, Delhi) Mob No: 9797951660 & Email: vasant@jkmail.com & mufti.wajid@jkmail.com	Mr. Reyaz Ahmad Mir (Authorized Officer) Email id: reyaz.mir@jkmail.com Mobile No. 9906980479 & Branch Manager Mr. Mufti Wajid Yaqub (Branch Office, Vasant Vihar, Delhi) Mob No: 9797951660 & Email: vasant@jkmail.com & mufti.wajid@jkmail.com
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) & Other Remittances/ detail/s by RTGS to Account Number	THE JAMMU AND KASHMIR BANK LIMITED Branch Office: Vasant Vihar, Delhi IFSC CODE: JAKA0VASANTJAKA0VASANT JAKA0ASANT Account Name:- RTGS Interbank Receipts Account Number:-0369072000000001.	THE JAMMU AND KASHMIR BANK LIMITED Branch Office: Vasant Vihar, Delhi IFSC CODE: JAKA0VASANTJAKA0VASANT JAKA0ASANT Account Name:- RTGS Interbank Receipts Account Number:-0369072000000001.

Date & time of E-auction	25.09.2026 from 03.00 pm to 4.00 pm	25.09.2026 from 03.00 pm to 4.00 pm
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Terms & Conditions of E-Auction are as under:

- i. The E-Auction is being held on "AS IS WHERE IS" "AS IS WHAT IS" AND "WHATEVER THERE IS" basis and will be conducted online. The bid document/format containing full details of the property and all the terms and conditions can be had from, and submitted on, the website "<http://sarfaesi.auctiontiger.net>" (contact person Ram Sharma -9978591888, Contact no. 079-68136880/68136837 Mob.: +91 9265562821/18 email: support@auctiontiger.net).
- ii. To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized officer, there are no encumbrances on the properties, except specifically disclosed herein. However, the intending bidders should make their own independent enquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of properties put on auction and claims/rights/dues affecting the property, prior to submitting their bid. The Authorized Officer/Secured Creditor shall not be responsible in any way for any third-party claims/rights/dues. The bidders shall satisfy themselves as to the description, condition or accuracy of the details regarding the properties given hereinabove. The E-Auction advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank.
- iii. The interested bidders shall submit their offer along with EMD through website <https://sarfaesi.auctiontiger.net> (the user ID and password can be obtained free of cost by registering name with "<http://sarfaesi.auctiontiger.net>") through their login ID and Password. The EMD 10% of RESERVE PRICE shall be payable through NEFT/RTGS (EMD remittance details given above) on or before 24.09.2026 (by or before 05.00 Pm). Please note that Cheques/Demand Drafts shall not be accepted as EMD amount.
- iv. The sale shall be subject to rules/conditions prescribed under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.
- v. The Authorized Officer is not bound to accept the highest offer, and the Authorized Officer has the absolute right to accept or reject any or all offer(s) or adjourn/postpone/cancel the e-auction without assigning any reason thereof.
- vi. The other terms and conditions of the e-Auction are available on the website <https://www.auctiontiger.net>.
Sd/- Authorized Officer,
Jammu & Kashmir Bank Ltd.
Registered Office: Corporate Headquarters M.A Road Srinagar-190001, J&K, India
CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048; T:+91(0)194 2481 930-35; F: +91(0)194 248 1928; E: info@jkmail.com W: www.jkbank.com

Food Ministry signs MoU with FCI to improve operational efficiency

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Food Ministry has signed an agreement with state-owned FCI to set targets for this fiscal, including modernising foodgrain management and improving operational efficiency.

The Food Corporation of India (FCI) is the nodal agency for procurement and distribution of foodgrains. According to an official statement on Tuesday, the Department of Food & Public Distribution (DFPD) and the FCI signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) for this fiscal.

“The MoU establishes a comprehensive performance framework for FCI, with defined targets aimed



at improving operational efficiency, strengthening accountability and accelerating modernisation in foodgrain management,” the

food ministry said.

The MoU focuses on various key areas, including reduction of storage losses, optimal utilisation of storage

capacity, improvement in logistics and supply chain management, and strengthening of quality control mechanisms.

According to the MoU, the FCI will also emphasise greater digitisation of business processes and adoption of modern information technology solutions to enhance efficiency.

As part of the modernisation agenda, the MoU provides for capacity building and skill development initiatives for FCI employees.

The pact introduces a measurable, outcome-oriented approach to FCI's functioning by linking its performance with clearly defined annual parameters, the statement said.

Adani Airports emerges as world’s third most valuable airport operators after \$1 B fundraise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Billionaire Gautam Adani's airport company is set to rank among the world's most valuable airport operators after securing about \$1 billion in fresh equity from a group of global and domestic investors, including Temasek, BlackRock-managed funds, Alpha Wave Global and Premji Invest.

The transaction values Adani Airports Holdings at about USD 18 billion before the investment. With the new capital, the implied post-money equity value is approximately \$19 billion, putting the Indian airport operator around third globally among major listed and recently valued airport operators, behind Spain's Aena



and Airports of Thailand on the basis of equity value, according to market research analysts. The comparison, however, may not strictly be like-for-like because Aena and Airports of Thailand are publicly traded companies, while Adani Airport Holdings is privately held within Adani Enterprises.

Under the agreements, the investor consortium will acquire newly issued shares in Adani Airport Holdings in three tranches and will collec-

tively hold about 5.54 per cent once the transaction is completed. The final tranche is expected by July 2027, according to a company statement.

The capital will be used to expand and modernise Adani's airport network, develop airport-linked commercial infrastructure and scale businesses such as ground handling and passenger services. The company aims to increase its annual airport capacity to about 200 million passengers.

ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund gets RBI nod to raise stake in four banks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

ICICI Prudential Asset Management Company has received the Reserve Bank's approval for enhancing its stake in four banks, including Kotak Mahindra Bank, up to 9.95 per cent. The other three lenders are CSB Bank, DCB Bank and AU Small Finance Bank.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), through different letters dated September 8, 2026, permitted ICICI Prudential



Asset Management Company Ltd (applicant) to acquire an aggregate holding of up to 9.95 per cent of the paid-up share capital or voting rights in these banks, ICICI Bank, the parent entity of the fund house, said in a

regulatory filing.

The approvals require the applicant to acquire major shareholding within a period of one year from the date of the RBI letters, failing which the approvals would stand cancelled, it said.

APSEZ expands east India operations with new 18 MMT Paradip dry bulk berth win

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Limited (APSEZ) has emerged as the highest bidder and received the Letter of Award (LoA) for the development and operation of two dry bulk berths at Paradip Port in Odisha.

The project, which will add 18 million metric tonnes (MMT) of mechanised dry bulk capacity, will take APSEZ's total portfolio from 653 MMT to 671 MMT. The company said the addition will support its target of

achieving 1 billion tonnes of cargo throughput by 2030.

Under the 30-year concession, the project will be developed under the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model. APSEZ will develop the CQ-I and CQ-II berths with mechanised cargo handling systems, deep-draft berths and large-scale storage infrastructure.

Ashwani Gupta, Whole-time Director and CEO, APSEZ, said the Paradip concession will strengthen the company's presence on the East Coast and expand its access to one of India's key industrial and mineral-rich hinterlands.



Located near major steel plants, Paradip is India's second-largest major port and an important bulk cargo gateway on the eastern seaboard. The new terminal is expected to

strengthen APSEZ's ability to handle growing volumes of coal, limestone and other dry bulk commodities.

The Paradip project will complement APSEZ's existing

140 MMT capacity across Haldia, Dhamra, Gopalpur and Gangavaram, while expanding its access to industrial and manufacturing clusters across eastern and central India.

APSEZ said the capacity addition comes amid high utilisation across East Coast ports and rising cargo demand, supported by steel-sector expansion and the government's push for domestic coal. The project is expected to help address regional capacity constraints and support industrial growth.

NHAI tightens plantation compliance norms for NH projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned NHAI on Wednesday said it has tightened compliance norms for plantation along the median and avenues of National Highway projects before the issuance of a provisional completion certificate.

Under the new guidelines, NHAI will ensure that median and avenue plantation is undertaken strictly in accordance with the respective contract/concession agreement and prescribed guidelines as per the Green Highways Policy, 2015 and other relevant guidelines issued by Ministry of Road Transport and Highways and NHAI, the state-owned entity said in a statement.

It said a key provision of



the guidelines is the introduction of a minimum threshold for the issuance of the provisional certificate of completion (PCC)/provisional commercial operation date (PCOD).

Plantation works will be considered compliant for the purpose of provisional comple-

tion certification only when plantation has been undertaken on at least 80 per cent of the available Right of Way (ROW) earmarked for plantation, with planted saplings recording a minimum survival rate of 90 per cent at the time of inspection by the officials, NHAI said.

The guidelines further stipulate that any plantation shortfall beyond the prescribed 80 per cent threshold must be highlighted along with specific timelines for completion, it added.

Appropriate financial holdings, as provided under the relevant contract/concession agreement, will be enforced until the balance plantation is completed and the prescribed target is fully achieved, it said.

NHAI said it has also strengthened plantation maintenance requirements during the operations and maintenance (O&M) period of the National Highways.

The release of O&M/annuity payments in engineering, procurement and construction (EPC), hybrid annuity mode (HAM) and build-operate-

transfer (BOT) annuity projects, as well as assessment of maintenance compliance in BOT-Toll projects will be subject to maintaining a minimum 90 per cent survival rate throughout the O&M period, it said.

The state-owned agency said it had earlier observed that development of plantation along the median and avenues, which is a contractual obligation, was often not accorded due importance at the time of issuing PCC/PCOD for National Highway projects.

The revised guidelines reinforce NHAI's commitment to integrate environmental sustainability and plantation management into the core implementation and maintenance framework of National Highway projects, it added.

Haryana, Australia explore cooperation in education, skills, innovation, investment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini held a high-level meeting in Chandigarh with a delegation led by Australian High Commissioner to India Philip Green to discuss strengthening cooperation between Haryana and Australia across education, higher education, skill development, innovation, agriculture, green energy, sports, tourism and investment.

The meeting focused particularly on creating global skills and employment opportunities for Haryana's

youth. Chief Minister Saini said India and Australia share a strong and comprehensive strategic partnership, with growing cooperation in trade, education, technology, innovation and skill development.

He said the state government's priority is to ensure that the benefits of strengthening India-Australia relations reach Haryana's youth, students, farmers, entrepreneurs and industries. Cooperation in education, skills, research, innovation and emerging technologies, he added, could provide fresh impetus to Haryana's development.



University and Innovation Cooperation

Discussions focused on strengthening collaboration between Haryana universities and leading Australian universities and research institutions. Joint research, student and faculty exchanges, and academic programmes in artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, agriculture, engineering, clean energy and public policy were among the areas discussed.

Possibilities of developing Centres of Excellence, research and innovation hubs, and emerging-technology training centres in Haryana were also explored.

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar
Engineering Department
Tender Notice
Tender Reference No. GNDU/ENGG/2026/09/01-02
The Engineering Department of Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar invites online bids for:-
(i) Construction of boundary wall at GNDU College Nakodar, Jalandhar (ii) Construction of Vermicompost Shed in RCC at Solid Liquid Resource Management Centre with GNDU Campus, Amritsar.
Closing date & time: **24-09-2026 upto 04:00 pm**
For details log onto www.aproc.punjab.gov.in
Note: Any Corrigendum/Addendum to the tender notice shall be published on the above website only.

2426/12/2026-27/14968 Dated CHD :- 09/09/2026

G.B. Pant University of Agriculture & Technology
Pan Nagar-263145, Udham Singh Nagar, Uttarakhand
EMPLOYMENT NOTICE NO. A-30/2026
Govind Ballabh Pant University of Agriculture & Technology, Pantnagar invites applications from the eligible candidates for selection to the posts of **Associate Professor (Acad. Level-13A)** in different disciplines of various colleges. Details of the Posts, Pay Scales, General Instructions and Application Forms are available on the website <https://www.gbpuat.ac.in>. Last date for the receipt of application form is **10.10.2026 till 05:00 PM** at the **Chief Personnel Office (Recruitment Section), Govind Ballabh Pant University of Agriculture & Technology, Pantnagar, District- Udham Singh Nagar, Uttarakhand, Pin-263145** by **Speed Post/Registered Post only**.
CHIEF PERSONNEL OFFICER

N Franklin Jayakumar assumes charge as CMD of Northern Coalfields

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

N Franklin Jayakumar has assumed charge as Chairman-cum-Managing Director (CMD) of Northern Coalfields Ltd (NCL), the Singrauli-based subsidiary of Coal India Ltd. He took charge on Tuesday. Jayakumar is a mining professional with over 34 years of experience in mechanised underground and opencast coal and lignite mining operations in India and abroad.

Before joining NCL, he was serving as Director (Technical), Operations, at South Eastern Coalfields Ltd (SECL), a subsidiary of Coal India Ltd, Northern Coalfields said in a statement. Under his leadership as Director (Technical), SECL achieved record coal production, offtake and OB removal, while driving mine modernisation and mechanisation. In SECL, he spearheaded sustain-



ability initiatives across solar, green mobility, coal gasification and energy storage and championed technology-led automation and transparency in coal sampling, the statement added.

A graduate in mining engineering from the College of Engineering, Guindy, Anna University, Chennai, Jayakumar holds a postgraduate diploma in environmental engineering and management from Central University, Hyderabad, and an MBA in Human Resource Management from Alagappa University, Tamil Nadu.

VTS Infosoft concludes 2nd IT Excellence Award 2026



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

VTS Infosoft, part of the KPMC Group, successfully concluded the 2nd IT Excellence Award 2026, themed “Beyond the Prompt”, at Radisson Blu Tower, Kaushambi, NCR Delhi. The event also marked the company's 13th anniversary and brought together more than 150 CXOs, CIOs, CTOs and business owners.

Keynote speakers Sanya Duggal, Biswajit Bhattacharya, Atul Tripathy and Vidhu Shekhar highlighted the

need for businesses to move beyond AI hype and focus on measurable return on investment. Awards were evaluated by a jury comprising Sanya Duggal and Sandeep Kumar from Microsoft, along with Rajesh Gupta, CTO and industry expert. Honours recognised excellence across Business Applications, Modern Workplace, and Cloud & AI. The event concluded with a closing note by Prabhat Kumar. VTS Infosoft also announced plans for a larger, full-day conclave alongside the 3rd edition in 2027.

India’s cargo and logistics exhibition landscape gets boost

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ MUMBAI

Messe Muenchen India has acquired the India International Cargo Show (IICS) from Upstream Business Solutions LLP, expanding its logistics trade-fair portfolio.

IICS 2025 attracted over 25,000 trade visitors from 80-plus countries and featured 200 exhibitors.

The acquisition brings IICS alongside Transport Logistics India, Air Cargo India, and the upcoming Project Cargo India, creating an integrated logistics ecosystem covering air, sea, rail, and road.

▼ BRIEFLY

Nyra becomes youngest Indian shooter to qualify for nationals



Delhi shooter Nyra Sharma, aged just 10 years and three months, has become the youngest Indian to qualify for the National Championship. Nyra secured her place in 10m air rifle after scoring 363/400 at the recently concluded All India Inter School Shooting Championship in Bhopal. Nyra trains at the TOPGUN Shooting Academy in Delhi and will now prepare for National Championship, scheduled to be held later this year.

She made her competitive debut at the Delhi State Championship in June, followed by the India Open in July at Dehradun. At only her third competition, she produced the score that earned her a place at the Nationals. Nyra's father, Prashant Sharma, said, "As a father, I feel immense pride and gratitude on seeing Nyra become India's youngest shooter to qualify for Nationals. This remarkable achievement is result of her hard work, discipline, and determination, along with the guidance and support of TOPGUN Shooting Academy." (PTI)

PSG starts title defense in Champions League



Paris Saint-Germain enters Champions League arena Wednesday as two-time title holder heads a heavyweight lineup of six games. PSG hosts Slovan Bratislava one day after 10 players in coach Luis Enrique's squad were nominated on shortlist of 30 for Ballon d'Or award.

Arsenal, the beaten finalist in May, starts in Napoli after topping the 36-team standings last season with eight straight wins and as the only unbeaten club.

Six-time European champion Liverpool, under new Spanish coach Andoni Iraola, hosts Atletico Madrid in a repeat of the opening round one year ago that was won 3-2 on captain Virgil van Dijk's stoppage-time header. Barcelona also starts at home against Feyenoord, which is coached by Giovanni van Bronckhorst, who returns to Camp Nou where he spent four years as a player and won Champions League in 2006. (AP)

India to face Pakistan in quarters of junior women's hockey Asia Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Moqi (China)

The Indian junior women's hockey team played out a goalless draw against China in its final elite pool match to set up a mouth-watering clash against Pakistan in the quarter-finals of the Junior Asia Cup here on Wednesday.

The result enabled India to finish the pool stage unbeaten with 10 points from three wins and a draw, securing the top spot in the elite pool due to a superior goal difference.

China started the contest on the front foot, consistently attacking the Indian half and pressuring the defence.

The hosts earned an early penalty corner, but India defended well to deny them the opportunity to take the lead. China were subsequently awarded a penalty stroke with more than seven minutes remaining in the opening quarter. India goalkeeper Nidhi, however, produced an excellent save to keep the score level and deny China a golden opportunity to break the deadlock.

The save lifted India's confidence as they began to grow into confidence and started to launch attacks of their own. China's defence remained organised and contained India's advances well, while the hosts also looked to threaten through counter-attacks.

But neither side could find the breakthrough as the first quarter



ended goalless.

India began the second quarter with attacking intent, looking to put more pressure on the Chinese defence. China, meanwhile, remained dangerous and earned a penalty corner with just over seven minutes remaining in the quarter. India once again defended resolutely to keep the hosts away.

India responded by putting together a period of sustained pressure and earned a penalty corner with just under three minutes remaining in the second quarter.

China did well to keep out the initial attempt, but India were awarded a re-awarded a penalty corner. The Chinese defence stood firm once again and cleared the danger as the second quarter too ended goalless.

India win two gold, four bronze at World Archery Para Series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

Reigning Paralympics champion Harvinder Singh and world Number 1 Sheetal Devi led the charge as India signed off their World Archery Para Series Stage III campaign on a high, winning two gold and four bronze medals, on the final day, here on Wednesday.

World No. 1 and reigning world champion Sheetal Devi held her nerve in a dramatic shoot-off to win the para compound women's individual gold, while double Paralympics medalist Harvinder, paired with Bhawna, helped India to gold in the para recurve mixed team event.

In the recurve mixed team final, double Paralympics medalist Harvinder and Bhawna made short work of China's Liang Qiurong and Xia Lei, winning 6-0 in straight sets. India took the opening set 35-31 before winning second 36-33 and completing the clean sweep with a 34-32 victory in third.

Bhawna then added another bronze in an all-Indian para recurve women's bronze-medal play-off, defeating compatriot Rajshree Rathod 6-0.



Sheetal returned in the evening session and produced a composed performance against Kazakhstan's Aizada Seidan in a thrilling compound women's individual final. Both the archers started with perfect 30s and remained locked at 59 after the second end, with both shooting 29. Aizada then edged ahead by a point in the third end after shooting 28 to Sheetal's 27. The fourth end ended 29-29, before Sheetal produced a 29 in the final end against Aizada's 28 to level the scores at 144-all and force a shoot-off.

Sheetal kept her composure when it mattered most, hitting a perfect 10, while Aizada managed a nine to hand the Indian the gold. Sheetal, thus, completed a medal double, having earlier teamed up with Toman Kumar to win bronze in compound mixed team event.

Kapur backs India's Asian Games golfers to end gold medal wait

HIMANK NEGI ■ New Delhi

Former Asian Games gold medalist Shiv Kapur believes India's golfers have the talent to end the country's long wait for another gold at the continental showpiece, saying anything less than the top prize would be a disappointment at the upcoming Aichi-Nagoya Games.

India will be represented by a six-member golf squad at the Asian Games, with Aditi Ashok, Diksha Dagar and Pranavi Urs making up the women's team and Yuvraj Sandhu, Veer Ahlawat and Saptak Talwar featuring in the men's competition. The team was selected on the basis of world rankings.

Kapur, who won the indi-

vidual gold at the 2002 Asian Games, said the achievement remains the biggest of his career and hoped the current gen-

eration can break India's gold-medal drought in golf.

"2002 is still fresh in my mind. It has been almost 25 years, but if anyone asks me what my number one achievement in golf, or the number one achievement in my career, is, it is still winning the gold medal," Kapur said on the sidelines of the jersey launch of RVR Delhi Blue Bulls.

"So, I will be cheering for them and hoping that the last one took 20-some years, so hopefully they will break the jinx this time and win a gold medal for the country, both as a team and individually. I think they have the ability, there is no doubt."

Kapur said India's



growing pool of talent has raised expectations, and the golfers should be aiming for nothing less than gold.

"There are very high expectations. I think we have a really good pool of talent in India. We are able to perform on the world stage now, and I think anything short of winning would be a disappoint-

ment, in my opinion. The talent is there, the ability is there," he said.

Gaurav Ghei, who is part of the Delhi franchise, also expressed confidence in India's golfers, particularly highlighting the strength of the women's game.

"They are all fantastic golfers, not just Aditi. I think Deeksha is doing fantastically well now on the Ladies European Tour, and I really have very high hopes for them," he said. Ghei, however, stressed the importance of embracing the occasion rather than becoming overwhelmed by the pressure of winning medals.

"I think the biggest thing for a team is to work hard and be prepared for tournament, but also to embrace occasion and enjoy it. Sometimes you get too consumed by thinking, 'I have to win a medal', or whatever," he said. (PTI)

DAILY SUDOKU

			5					
				3		1	9	4
	9		8	1				
4			1					6
	3						2	
1					5			3
				9	8		6	
3	6	5		2				
					1			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (9.9.26)

5	7	6	8	9	3	4	2	1
2	1	3	6	5	4	7	9	8
4	8	9	1	2	7	3	6	5
3	9	5	4	8	2	1	7	6
8	2	7	5	1	6	9	4	3
1	6	4	3	7	9	8	5	2
9	5	1	7	6	8	2	3	4
6	3	2	9	4	1	5	8	7
7	4	8	2	3	5	6	1	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
THURSDAY | SEPTEMBER 10, 2026

1		2		3		4		5		6		7
8		9						10				
		11				12						
13				14				15				17
						18				19		
20			21									
22										23		
26	27			28				29				30
31								32				33
						34						35
36										37		
												38

- ACROSS**
- 3 Exclusive shop at Ponders End (5)
8 Painter whose work centre was in bed (5)
10 Complaint from an officer, I see (5)
11 Perhaps not all that heavy? (3)
12 Worries about the guitar parts (5)
13 In general, knaves get ahead (7)
15 From him, sour grapes were just a bit of a story (5)
18 Slippery customer getting some free electricity (3)
19 Ruined when performed by the United Nations (6)
21 Weather feature that makes you take the bike out farther (7)
22 So carelessly shut (4)
23 Like the drinks often on sale without
- DOWN**
- 1 Drink nearly all of what there is (5)
2 Plays around with primates (7)
4 To pop, it tastes sweeter (4)
5 That of a fuel can be high (6)
6 In the position to dispense dopes (5)
7 Spike with a bent point? (5)
9 It could carry an elephant, one imagines (3)
12 A review of one's rashness? (7)
14 Dry in next to no time (3)
16 City of changing moods (5)
17 Place in the upper three (5)
19 Tommy will be in it all the same (7)
- 20 Remnants left behind by a tearaway? (5)
21 Measure and cut out a piece of webbing (5)
23 Thus strengthened and comforted (7)
24 Seated in order to seem dignified (6)
25 The German girl has a key (3)
27 The side of a sock (5)
28 Devil of a strange omen to many! (5)
30 King of snakes? (5)
32 A squashed gnat could spoil the flavour (4)
33 Twin very close to his brother in a Michael Jackson song (3)

Shelton ends Alcaraz's title reign, will face Tiafoe in US Open semis

BRIAN MAHONEY ■ New York

Ben Shelton had gone toe-to-toe with Carlos Alcaraz for five exhausting sets and finally at 3:33 a.m. Wednesday came the chance to end US Open champion's title reign. Shelton fired an ace at 146 mph, ball that Alcaraz couldn't have gotten back even with fresh legs. That gave Shelton a 6-7 (5), 6-1, 6-3, 1-6, 7-6 (10-7) victory in marathon tussle that was the latest-finishing match in US Open history. "I'm tired. It was a war," Shelton said.

"Carlos is one of the greatest champions of our sport. It was the most enjoyable match I've had in my career, for sure."

Alcaraz had his 18-match winning streak in Grand Slam tournaments ended in a match that lasted 4 hours, 28 minutes, after he fought deep into the night and early into the next morning in a bid to get his hands on the trophy again.

"I mean it was close, it was really close, so I was disappointed I didn't get the win at the end," the Number 2-seeded Alcaraz



said. "But I'm happy, I am proud of myself about how I fought. As I said, physically I was really tired but I found a way to push myself." Shelton next plays No. 11 seed Frances Tiafoe, who kept coming back until he had reached his third US Open semifinal, beating Alex Michelsen 5-7, 3-6, 7-5, 6-3, 7-6 (10-6) on Tuesday. The US is guaranteed to have a

representative in Sunday's final as it seeks its first men's major title since Andy Roddick lifted the title here in 2003.

Alcaraz had played in the previous latest finish at the U.S. Open when he outlasted Jannik Sinner in a match that finished at 2:50 a.m. in the 2022 quarterfinals en route to his first Grand Slam title at 19. (AP)

Frances Tiafoe reaches US Open semifinals

BRIAN MAHONEY ■ New York

Frances Tiafoe kept coming back until he had reached his third U.S. Open semifinal, beating Alex Michelsen 5-7, 3-6, 7-5, 6-3, 7-6 (10-6) on Tuesday. Tiafoe, who lost the first two sets and then trailed 3-0 in the fifth, finally ended the match in 4 hours, 38 minutes. He then jogged over to the other side of the net, where the 22-year-old Michelsen cried on his shoulder after a devastating end to his first career major quarterfinal.

Tiafoe said his performance to start the match was slow and flat.

"It wasn't good, let's put it that way. It wasn't good," he said. "Three out of five is a blessing, because you have time to get it together. I definitely waited for the last minute."

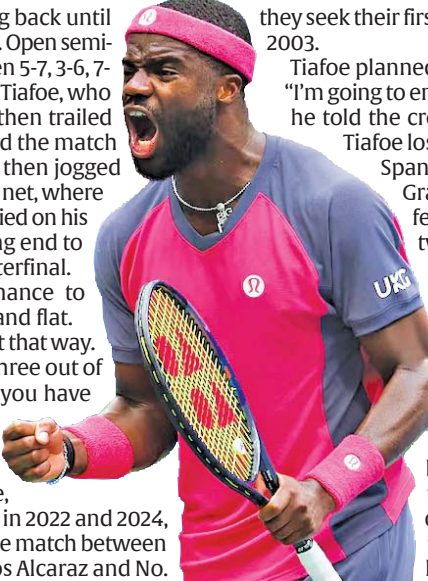
The No. 11-seeded Tiafoe, who reached the final four in 2022 and 2024, awaits the winner of the late match between defending champion Carlos Alcaraz and No.

8 Ben Shelton, who will try to guarantee the Americans have someone in the final Sunday as they seek their first men's Grand Slam title since 2003.

Tiafoe planned to watch some of it. "I'm going to enjoy this one, though. Let's go!" he told the crowd in Arthur Ashe Stadium.

Tiafoe lost to Alcaraz in 2022, when the Spaniard won his first of seven Grand Slam titles. Tiafoe lost to fellow American Taylor Fritz two years later, when the U.S. came closest to ending it's men's drought that dates to Andy Roddick's title in Flushing Meadows.

It certainly didn't appear Tiafoe would be going back this time, after Michelsen continued his run through his breakout tournament. He was the only man who hadn't dropped a set, and he served to win the match with a 5-4 lead in the third. (AP)



Duleep Trophy final: East Zone inch closer to title

G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Chennai

Ishan Kishan and South Zone skipper Tilak Varma underlined their red ball chops with 80 and 99 respectively, but former's half-century has more contextual value as it placed East Zone firmly on course for a Duleep Trophy triumph on the fourth day of the final here on Wednesday.

Tilak's 211-ball knock lifted South to 336 all out in their first innings but still remained 372 runs adrift of East's first dig total of 708.

In their second innings, East moved to 212 for five at close, for an overall lead of 584 runs. Kumar Kushagra (34) and Kounain Quraishi (26) were batting at close and have raised 52 runs for the unbroken sixth wicket.

But those team numbers now carry a mere academic significance as East already have their hands around this season's Duleep Trophy, courtesy that irreversibly massive first-innings lead. However, with a couple of important Test assignments coming up - away against New Zealand and subsequently at home against Australia - the selectors now have two solid options to mull over in front of them. Kishan, who made an expansive 270 in the first innings here, was comfortable from ball one in the



ensuing essay as well during his 98-ball knock.

The left-hander started his run-making with a six off off-spinner Tripurana Vijay over mid-wicket and never really took his feet off the

pedal. Kishan went after Vijay again towards the backend of his innings, hammering him for 4, 6, 6, 4 in successive balls in the 26th over.

Moments before that DRS saved Kishan, who added 146 runs for the

third wicket with Shikhar Mohan, from a leg-before decision after on-field umpire Rohan Pandit upheld leg-spinner Shreyas Gopal's appeal.

East took tea at 95 for two, having swelled the lead by 467 runs.

But the 20-minute break seemed to have affected Kishan's rhythm as he soon got out, lofting pacer MD Nidheesh to Devdutt Padikkal inside the leg-side circle.

The motley Chepauk crowd hence could not see another Kishan hundred and they also had to endure the disappointment of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's early dismissal.

After DRS saved him from Vijay's leg before appeal on 6, Sooryavanshi could not build something bigger, getting stumped off the same bowler by Narayan Jagadeesan.

Much before that, the audience also could not see a three-figure knock from Tilak, who resumed from overnight 56.

His innings helped South, overnight 242 for six, to go past the 300-run mark, but the left-hander will rue missing a second consecutive ton after making one in the semifinal last week at Bengaluru.

The Hyderabad batter did not let go his defence-first approach even when wickets began to tumble at the other

end. Eventually, his first attempt to hit out resulted in a return catch to off-spinner Quraishi.

But later in the day, another Hyderabad player had his best outing in recent times.

Mohammed Siraj had looked a distant shadow of his intense self since the tour to Sri Lanka, often bowling with a shorter run-up and reduced speed. He struggled to summon the steely self in humid conditions when the 36-year-old East Zone quick Mohammed Shami made the new and old ball talk even while bowling well within himself.

But in East Zone's second innings here, Siraj looked to have regained some of his familiar sharpness. The increased nip, accuracy and corrected length meant that Siraj remained a threat to batters' edge.

He was eventually rewarded when East Zone opener Abhimanyu Easwaran tamely guided a delivery to Padikkal at slip.

However, those were tiny glittering nuggets without making any significant alteration to the match's course. (PTI)



G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Chennai

The ongoing Duleep Trophy might not have panned out in his favour, but South Zone captain Tilak Varma has set a new goal for himself -- winning the upcoming three-match T20I series against Afghanistan.

East Zone has built an overall lead of 584 runs to all but clinch the domestic season opener here, but Tilak, India's T20I vice-captain, found some solace in an immediate chance to redeem himself. "Yeah, the (personal) form has been really good. But at the same point, it's a different format (against Afghanistan). So, I should change my gears again. I'm pretty confident about it," Tilak said after the fourth day of the Duleep Trophy final.

"My goal now is to win the Afghanistan series. So I'll be going

with the same confidence and let's see how it goes," he added.

India will start their campaign against Afghanistan with the first T20I at New Delhi on September 13.

But how tough is it to shift to white ball format after playing the red-ball game for a little over a month?

"I would not say it is that easy, but we have got a couple of days to practice. We have also changed from red ball to white ball in both domestic and international cricket. So, this is also the same thing. "I have played Ranji Trophy earlier, and from there I went to the international white-ball series. I got adjusted to it. So, yeah, I'm confident that two days of practice is enough and from there we can go for the Afghanistan series," he noted. The 23-year-old maintained he sees the traditional format as his 'A Game.' (PTI)

Asia Cup: India start favourites in high stakes semifinal against Bangladesh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

Seven-time champions India will start as overwhelming favourites when they face a gritty Bangladesh side in the first semifinal of the Women's Asia Cup here on Thursday — a high-stakes clash defined by intense on-field rivalry and underlying political subtext.

Diplomatic relations between New Delhi and Dhaka have experienced a strain following political transitions in Bangladesh, and broader tensions between the two neighbours in the past have often spilled over into the cricket field, and the trend is likely to continue.

Indian men's team's tour of Bangladesh has been postponed on multiple occasions due to prevailing political tension. As far as cricket is concerned, Harman preet Kaur's side have been in imperious form throughout the continental tournament, topping Group A



after winning all their matches, and they are heavily favoured to march one step closer to another continental title triumph.

India's campaign so far in the tournament has been highlighted by dominant displays, none more so than

their clinical group-stage thrashing of traditional rivals Pakistan, whom they skittled for just 55 before romping to a seven-wicket victory.

India's batting unit wears a formidable look. The incredible Smriti Mandhana enters this crucial fixture riding high on confidence after her exploits earlier in the tournament, highlighted by a belligerent 64-ball 124 against Hong Kong that further cemented her status as one of the game's premier modern-day batters.

England leaves Pakistan reeling on 100-7 in 3rd test



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Birmingham (England)

Pakistan fielded a new-look team but the same old problems resurfaced as it plunged to 100-7 at lunch after being put into bat by England in the third and final cricket test at Edgbaston on Wednesday.

The touring team, which caused a major surprise by sending seven players home after its second-test defeat at Lord's, plus the head coach and the bowling coach, made four changes to the side but the batters were all at sea yet again.

England claimed a first breakthrough when the recalled Saim Ayub was trapped lbw for a duck to give quick bowler Ollie Robinson his 100th test wicket. Jofra Archer then forced Azan Awaiz into offering mid-on fielder Josh Tongue a low, diving catch off a leading edge. Abdullah Shafique was next to go, caught low down by Dan Lawrence at third slip off Robinson.

Shan Masood became the fourth wicket to fall when he lobbed the ball to mid-wicket off fast bowler Archer following a poor cross-bat stroke.

Hardik Pandya named in India A squad for Aus A one dayers



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Senior all-rounder Hardik Pandya has been picked for the three-match one day series against Australia A in October subject to full fitness, the BCCI announced on Wednesday.

The 32-year-old Pandya last played a competitive match during last edition's disastrous IPL campaign for Mumbai Indians.

Since then, he has been out of action with latest being quadriceps injury which prevented him from attaining full fitness.

The tour will start with the first multi-day match in Puducherry from September 22, followed by the second game from September 29 at the same venue. The multi-day matches will be followed by three one-dayers on October 6, 9 and 11 in Puducherry.

Interestingly, India's senior team will be playing three ODIs against the West Indies on September 27, 30 and October 3.

Devdutt Padikkal will lead the India A multi-day squad while Ruturaj Gaikwad will captain the one-day side in the upcoming home series in which they will play two multi-day red ball games and three 50-over matches.

Sri Lanka Cricket faces estimated revenue loss of \$20 million after losing CT rights

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Sri Lanka Cricket (SLC) is facing an estimated revenue loss of \$20 million (₹188 crore) after being stripped of the hosting rights for next year's inaugural ICC Women's Champions Trophy tournament. The tournament, originally slated to be hosted by Sri Lanka, has been relocated to India and will take place from February 14 to 28, 2027, with matches scheduled in Mumbai and Vadodara.

"There will certainly be a hosting fee paid to us. I believe it is around 2 million dollars. At the same time, the SLC would have to incur expenditure sprucing up places and getting the facilities up to scratch," Prakash Schaffter, SLC's transformation committee secretary, told reporters. While withdrawing the event from Sri Lanka, the ICC cited ongoing government interference and the



absence of an elected administration at SLC.

Last week the ICC announced its decision to move the six-nation tournament to India as Sri Lanka's current governing body revamp operation was not in line with the world governing body's rules.

Indian women's rugby sevens begin Asian Games preparations with national camp

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

The Indian senior women's rugby sevens team has begun its preparation for the upcoming Asian Games here with coach Terence Joseph saying the focus of the national camp will be on execution and consistency.

The camp is being held at the Sports Authority of India's Netaji Subhas Eastern Centre in Kolkata, which has been the home base for the Indian rugby team ahead of major international competitions.

The Indian eyes will compete in the women's rugby sevens tournament at the Paloma Mizuho Rugby Stadium in Nagoya from October 1 to 3. India has been drawn in Pool B alongside defending champions



China, Hong Kong China and Malaysia.

"The Asian Games is a big tournament for us. We are looking at details and consistency from the team. A lot depends on how we

execute our plans in Japan," Joseph said during a press conference in SAI Kolkata. "SAI Kolkata has been the home for the Indian rugby team. We have been conducting camps here for the past three years."

IOA panel to probe Asunta's harassment charge

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Indian Olympic Association (IOA) has constituted a four-member independent inquiry committee headed by retired High Court judge Deepa Sharma to probe the allegations of harassment and intimidation levelled against Hockey India secretary Bhola Nath Singh by former women's team captain Asunta Lakra.

The panel, formed following a directive from the Sports Ministry, includes former track-and-field athlete Vandana Rao, former women's hockey team captain Mamta Kharb, and lawyer Sitwat Nabi as members.

Lakra, who is also a member of Hockey India's Executive Board, had accused Singh of threatening and harassing her after she objected to the alleged sexual harassment of girls in Jharkhand at the hands of local coach Sudhir Golla.



Hockey India has been directed to handle all requisite payments concerning the committee's honorarium, travel, accommodation, and incidental expenses.

"Hockey India is also requested to extend its full cooperation to the

committee and to ensure that all relevant documents, information and such other assistance as may be required is made available to the committee in a timely manner..." IOA President PT Usha's letter to HI stated.

India's tour of New Zealand: Ticket sales soar past 50,000

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Auckland

The marquee series against India starting late October has set the cash registers ringing at New Zealand Cricket headquarters as the parent body confirmed sale of more than 50,000 tickets since going on sale just over two weeks ago.

Commercially the most viable team in world cricket, India is coming to New Zealand after a gap of six years to play five T20Is, five ODIs and two Test matches. According to a press release: "Ticket sales opened to the public on Monday after a two week pre-sale window for Cricket Nation members, Sky customers, and ANZ customers, with several matches on track to sell out, including the second T20I against India in Christchurch which sits at 75 per cent sold out."

"High demand at Eden Park has



required the stadium's sixth tier of seating to open for the first time since the 2019 India tour of New Zealand, with the upper level available for the fourth T20I against India on Friday 30 October," it further stated.

NZC's Head of Marketing Tim Ellis said momentum for the tour was growing. "Being able to open up the top level of Eden Park for the first time in years is really exciting and speaks to the swell of excitement building around the tour.